

Emergency De- escalation Protocol

For the Strait of Hormuz Crisis

A Framework for Immediate Stabilization and Verified Reciprocal Motion

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Preamble

The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran, hereafter referenced as "the Parties," recognize that the current escalation in and around the Strait of Hormuz poses an acute threat to regional stability, global energy security, and the lives of civilian seafarers.

The Parties agree to address the immediate maritime crisis as a discrete, time-limited track. This Protocol addresses only maritime de-escalation, proxy management, and crisis stabilization.

The United States affirms it does not intend to initiate offensive military action against Iranian territory during the term of this Protocol, subject to the inherent right of self-defense under Article 51 of the United Nations Charter.

This Protocol constitutes a transactional stabilization arrangement, not recognition of government, political system, or regional policies. Nothing here grants amnesty or retrospective forgiveness for prior actions.

The framework architecture acknowledges that Iran's leadership operates within domestic political constraints, including hardline opposition to engagement with the United States. Compliance with this Protocol reflects sovereign decision-making and does not constitute acceptance of external political demands. This acknowledgment creates space for both Parties to explain delays or adjustments without admitting weakness or conceding position.

This Protocol rests upon five foundational principles:

1. **Synchronized Reciprocal Motion:** No Party provides unilateral advance concessions. Every obligation pairs with an immediate, verifiable, proportional counterpart.
2. **Mutual Architecture:** Each constraint functions as a feature of the shared framework, binding both Parties equally, rather than a unilateral restraint by one Party for the benefit of the other.
3. **Performance-Contingent Benefit:** Every benefit remains conditional. Each Party retains an orderly exit pathway on fourteen days' notice. No benefit is unconditional.
4. **Sovereign Equality:** The United Nations, through its existing agencies and the good offices of the UN Secretary-General, facilitates, observes, and supports implementation. Neither Party holds unilateral control over the framework. The Sultanate of Oman, the State of Qatar, and the Islamic Republic of Pakistan serve as primary facilitators. No external power assumes a guarantor role.
5. **Partial Success:** Failure in one zone or one obligation does not suspend operations in certified zones or completed obligations. Progress banks where it is made, and a localized failure stays localized.

The Parties adopt this Protocol in good faith, recognizing that the alternative to negotiated de-escalation is a return to military confrontation that serves the interests of neither side and endangers the broader international community.

Article 1: Situational Assessment

1.1 Current Crisis Indicators

The following conditions define the present emergency and establish the urgency of immediate reciprocal action:

- Commercial vessels sustained damage in the Strait of Hormuz on 7 July 2026, disrupting transit through the world's most critical energy chokepoint.
- The United States executed military strikes against Iranian air defense systems, coastal surveillance systems, surface-to-air missiles, anti-ship cruise missiles, and drone launch sites on 7 July 2026.
- The Islamic Republic of Iran attacked United States military bases in Kuwait and Bahrain on 9 July 2026 and issued a formal diplomatic warning of decisive measures to protect Iranian interests and national security.
- The United States revoked the temporary sanctions waiver for Iranian oil exports, tightening economic pressure at a moment of maximum military tension.
- The Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding of 17 June 2026, signed by the Presidents of both Parties, established a 60-day framework for comprehensive settlement. That framework faces imminent collapse.
- Qatar, Oman, Pakistan, the European Union, and the People's Republic of China actively urge both Parties to remain committed to the Islamabad MOU and pursue de-escalation through dialogue.

1.2 Shared Interests in De-escalation

Despite the present confrontation, both Parties share identifiable interests in immediate stabilization:

- Global energy markets remain highly volatile. Brent crude trades at elevated levels, and sustained disruption of Hormuz transit threatens a worldwide supply shock.
- Neither Party possesses a militarily decisive advantage that produces a favorable outcome through continued escalation.
- The domestic political costs of renewed full-scale hostilities exceed the costs of a structured, verifiable de-escalation in both capitals.

- The existing Islamabad MOU provides a verified foundation of reciprocal commitments that both Parties have already accepted in principle.
- Third parties, including the Sultanate of Oman, the State of Qatar, and the Islamic Republic of Pakistan, stand ready to facilitate, observe, and support implementation.

1.3 Scope of This Protocol

This Protocol addresses exclusively the immediate de-escalation of the present Hormuz crisis. It operates as a bridging instrument that activates the stabilization mechanisms of the Islamabad MOU and prevents collapse into renewed hostilities while the Parties pursue comprehensive settlement through the existing 60-day negotiating window.

This Protocol creates no precedent for future negotiations. Each provision is sui generis, tailored to the July 2026 emergency. No inference arises from any provision regarding positions on matters not expressly addressed herein. Either Party asserts in any forum that this Protocol has no precedential value. No provision of any Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

This Protocol references Annex A, the Implementation Roadmap, which contains the detailed day-by-day milestones, responsible parties, and verification criteria for each action item under this Protocol.

1.4 Institutional Continuity Clause

This Protocol is binding on the institutions of both Parties, not on any individual leader, official, or officeholder. The obligations, rights, and mechanisms established herein survive changes in leadership, succession, interim governance arrangements, or constitutional transitions in either Party. The Joint Commission's authority is derived from this Protocol, not from the personal authority of any signatory. Neither Party invokes a leadership transition, succession process, or temporary governing arrangement as grounds for suspension, delay, or non-performance of any obligation under this Protocol.

This clause is non-waivable. Neither Party accepts a reservation to this clause.

1.5 Succession Non-Disruption Principle

The Parties acknowledge that the Islamic Republic of Iran possesses a constitutional succession mechanism under Article 111 of its Constitution, providing for a Provisional Leadership Council composed of the President, the Chief Justice, and a member of the Guardian Council. The Parties agree that:

- The activation of this mechanism does not constitute a force majeure event.
- The Joint Commission continues to operate without interruption during any leadership transition.

- All communications, notifications, and certifications required under this Protocol are transmitted to and received from the office of the Presidency or the acting head of government, who serves as the continuity point of contact during any succession period.
- Neither Party exploits a leadership transition in the other Party to seek renegotiation, suspension, or termination of this Protocol.
- The 14-day exit ramp (Article 12.2) and the 30-day clean-break withdrawal (Article 12.3) remain available to a transitioning state through its acting executive authority, but neither provision is accelerated or triggered by succession proceedings alone.

1.6 Diplomatic Recognition of Interim Authorities

For the purpose of implementing this Protocol, the Joint Commission recognizes the Provisional Leadership Council established under Iran's Article 111, or any successor body exercising executive authority during a leadership transition, as the legitimate counterparty for all Protocol-related communications, certifications, and decisions. Neither Party uses the temporary nature of an interim governing arrangement as justification for delay, non-response, or non-compliance. The Omani, Qatari, and Pakistani facilitators verify the authority of any interim representative presenting credentials to the Joint Commission.

1.7 Institutional Designation of Successor Signatories

The Protocol enters into force upon signature by authorized representatives of both Parties. If either Party's signatory no longer holds office, the Protocol remains in full force. The successor to that office, or the acting head of government during a transition period, is automatically deemed the successor signatory with full authority to execute all obligations, certifications, and decisions under this Protocol. No additional signature, ratification, or legislative approval the Protocol continues binding on a transitioning state without additional action.

1.8 Institutional Point of Contact (IPOC)

Each Party designates an Institutional Point of Contact (IPOC) who is not the head of state, head of government, foreign minister, or any political appointee whose tenure is tied to a specific administration. The IPOC is a career official in a permanent ministry or agency (e.g., Ministry of Foreign Affairs permanent under-secretary, National Security Council executive secretary) who maintains continuity of communication regardless of leadership changes.

The IPOC: receives all Protocol notifications on behalf of their Party; confirms receipt within 24 hours of any notification; maintains the secure communication channel during transitions; and briefs incoming leadership on Protocol obligations within 72 hours of any leadership change.

Change of IPOC requires 14 days' written notice to the Joint Commission. During any IPOC transition, both the outgoing and incoming IPOCs are simultaneously authorized to receive and confirm notifications.

Article 2: Immediate De-escalation Measures (0-72 Hours)

The following measures activate simultaneously upon signature of this Protocol. No measure stands alone. Every action by one Party triggers a corresponding verified action by the other Party within the same 24-hour cycle. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

2.1 Definitions

For the purposes of this Protocol, the following terms have the specified meanings:

- "Kinetic incident" means any exchange of gunfire, detonation of explosive ordnance, collision resulting from deliberate offensive action, or damage to a vessel, aircraft, or facility caused by hostile military action. Technical malfunctions, navigational accidents, and force majeure events do not constitute kinetic incidents.
- "Cyber disruption" means any unauthorized electronic intrusion, denial-of-service attack, or data corruption targeting navigation systems, port infrastructure, vessel traffic management, or communications networks essential to Hormuz transit operations.

2.2 Maritime Standstill

The framework architecture establishes an immediate maritime standstill in the Strait of Hormuz and surrounding waters:

- The Islamic Republic of Iran suspends all patrol boat operations, fast attack craft sorties, drone overflights, and mine-laying activities by both the IRGC-Navy and the regular Artesh Navy within the commercial transit corridor of the Strait of Hormuz for a period of 72 hours from the hour of signature.
- The United States suspends all naval patrol operations, reconnaissance overflights, and forward deployment of strike assets within five nautical miles of the Iranian coast and the Hormuz transit corridor for the same 72-hour period.
- Neither Party deploys additional naval combatants into the Persian Gulf or the Gulf of Oman during the standstill or clearance period. Neither Party reinforces existing naval positions with additional personnel, aircraft, or weapons systems.

- Both Parties refrain from increasing airborne intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) activity in the vicinity of the Strait during the standstill and clearance periods. Both Parties maintain ISR operations at pre-crisis baseline levels only.
- Both Parties maintain existing naval positions outside the standstill zone and retain the inherent right to self-defense under Article 51 of the United Nations Charter against any armed attack.
- The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations (UKMTO) Centre in Dubai and the International Maritime Organization (IMO) verify compliance through multi-sensor fusion: satellite AIS monitoring, synthetic aperture radar (SAR) satellite surveillance, high-resolution optical satellite imagery, and neutral naval observation coordinated through the Omani Royal Navy.

2.3 Airspace Deconfliction

The framework architecture establishes explicit airspace rules for the standstill period:

- Both Parties suspend all military aircraft overflights within the Hormuz transit corridor, defined as the airspace from surface to 50,000 feet above mean sea level between coordinates 25.9N 56.4E and 27.1N 56.2E.
- Unarmed reconnaissance drones operating above 50,000 feet maintain their existing flight paths but do not deviate toward new targets within the corridor. Any deviation triggers a Category A deviation review.
- Commercial aviation continues on existing air traffic control routes. Neither Party diverts military aircraft onto commercial air corridors.
- The Omani Royal Navy air traffic coordination cell monitors all airspace activity and reports hourly to the Joint Commission.

2.3A High-Altitude ISR Aircraft Restrictions

The framework architecture establishes explicit restrictions on high-altitude intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) aircraft to prevent misinterpretation and escalation. Unrestricted ISR activity above the corridor creates the same escalation risk as activity within it.

- Neither Party increases ISR sortie frequency above the pre-crisis baseline within 20 nautical miles of the Hormuz transit corridor, regardless of altitude. This restriction applies to all fixed-wing ISR platforms including RC-135 Rivet Joint, P-8 Poseidon, RQ-4 Global Hawk, MQ-4C Triton, and equivalent signals intelligence (SIGINT) aircraft.
- Existing ISR flight paths above 50,000 feet remain at pre-crisis routing and frequency. Neither Party diverts high-altitude ISR assets toward new collection targets within the corridor or within 20 nautical miles of the corridor boundaries.

- SIGINT collection aircraft operating outside the 20-nautical-mile corridor zone maintain their existing orbits and do not establish new collection positions targeting Iranian or United States military communications within the standstill zone.
- Any increase in ISR activity above baseline, or any new ISR orbit within 20 nautical miles of the corridor, constitutes a Category A deviation and triggers recalibration dialogue under Article 5A.
- The Omani Royal Navy air traffic coordination cell monitors all aircraft activity, including high-altitude transits, and reports hourly to the Joint Commission on ISR sortie counts and routing.

2.3B Intelligence Collection Vessel Restrictions

The framework architecture prohibits the introduction of new intelligence-collection vessels into the Hormuz operational area. SIGINT ships, ELINT trawlers, disguised surveillance vessels, and civilian-hulled intelligence platforms constitute escalation vectors that threaten mutual confidence.

- Neither Party deploys new intelligence-collection vessels within 20 nautical miles of the Hormuz transit corridor for the duration of this Protocol. Vessels already present before Protocol signature maintain their existing positions but do not advance toward new collection stations.
- This restriction covers: dedicated SIGINT ships; ELINT collection vessels; ocean surveillance ships; civilian-hulled platforms conducting intelligence collection; and any vessel whose primary mission is signals, electronic, or communications intelligence collection.
- Existing naval combatants with organic intelligence-collection capabilities (e.g., Aegis-class cruisers, destroyers with SIGINT suites) are not subject to this restriction provided they remain within their assigned patrol sectors and do not reposition specifically to enhance collection against the other Party.
- Any new intelligence-collection vessel entering the 20-nautical-mile zone constitutes a Category B disruption unless the entering Party notifies the Joint Commission 48 hours in advance and obtains confirmation that the other Party raises no objection.
- The Omani Royal Navy coastal radar network tracks all vessel movements within the 20-nautical-mile zone. UKMTO cross-references vessel registrations against known intelligence-collection platforms and reports anomalies to the Joint Commission within 4 hours.

2.4 Cessation of Hostile Operations

The framework architecture excludes offensive military operations against the other Party during the standstill period:

- The United States does not initiate offensive military action against Iranian military installations, critical infrastructure, or government targets during the 72-hour standstill period.
- The Islamic Republic of Iran does not initiate offensive military action against United States military assets, commercial vessels, or allied installations during the 72-hour standstill period.
- Both Parties direct their regional partners and proxies to stand down from offensive operations during the standstill period. Article 7 of this Protocol defines specific proxy groups and measurable stand-down indicators.
- Both Parties refrain from conducting or supporting cyber disruptions targeting navigation systems, port infrastructure, or vessel traffic management in the Hormuz transit corridor during the standstill period.
- Both Parties guarantee safe passage to all commercial vessels transiting certified zones. Neither Party attacks, interdicts, or harasses commercial shipping in zones certified as clear by UNMAS.
- Any deviation from the cessation triggers immediate consultation through the Deconfliction Hotline via the Omani relay within two hours, not retaliatory escalation.

2.5 Emergency Humanitarian Corridor

The framework architecture guarantees unimpeded humanitarian transit regardless of the military situation:

- Medical evacuation vessels, humanitarian supply ships, and vessels carrying food, water, and disaster relief materials transit the Strait of Hormuz without interference, inspection, or delay from either Party.
- Both Parties grant safe passage to vessels flying the flag of the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC), the United Nations World Food Programme (WFP), the World Health Organization (WHO), and other certified humanitarian organizations.
- The humanitarian corridor operates under direct supervision of the ICRC and the IMO and is subject to neither sanctions enforcement nor military targeting for the duration of this Protocol.

2.6 The 24/7 Deconfliction Hotline

The Deconfliction Hotline operates continuously between the Parties through the Omani relay. The Hotline handles operational military communications exclusively.

- The Hotline connects operational military commanders on both sides through the Omani Royal Navy as a neutral relay. No direct military-to-military communication between Iranian and United States personnel occurs unless both Parties expressly agree.
- Either Party initiates a Hotline call at any time, for any reason, without preconditions. The receiving Party responds within 30 minutes.
- Hotline communications remain confidential. Neither Party records, publishes, or references Hotline communications in public statements without the express consent of both Parties.
- Failure to respond to three consecutive Hotline calls within 30 minutes constitutes a Category A deviation, addressed through recalibration dialogue.

2.7 The June 2026 Communication Channel

The framework architecture formalizes the communication channel agreed between the Parties in June 2026 for Hormuz incident resolution:

- The Communication Channel operates as a structured incident-resolution mechanism, modeled on the channel agreed in June 2026 and confirmed by Iran's parliament speaker.
- The Channel operates within a 30-day initial activation window, during which both Parties test connectivity, confirm response protocols, and establish baseline communication rhythms.
- The Channel supplements the Deconfliction Hotline. The Hotline handles immediate operational incidents; the Channel handles political-level incident assessment and de-escalation recommendations.
- Both Parties commit to responding to any Channel communication within 4 hours during the 30-day initial window, and within 2 hours after the initial window completes.

2.8 Verification of the 72-Hour Standstill

The following multi-source mechanism verifies the 72-hour standstill:

- Multi-sensor fusion confirms the absence of naval vessel movement within the standstill zone by both Parties. The system integrates AIS transponder data, SAR satellite imagery from commercial providers, high-resolution optical satellite imagery, and coastal radar feeds from the Omani Royal Navy and UKMTO.

- The Omani Royal Navy maintains continuous visual and radar observation of the Hormuz transit corridor and reports hourly to the Joint Commission.
- Commercial vessel traffic resumes under IMO-coordinated vessel monitoring, with transit data published in real time through the IMO's Global Integrated Shipping Information System (GISIS).
- Either Party reports a suspected event through the 24/7 Deconfliction Hotline. The Joint Commission convenes within four hours of any such report to assess and classify under the system described in Article 5.

Article 3: Phased Mine Clearance and Corridor Opening

The Parties recognize that real-world mine clearance in a contested chokepoint requires a realistic timeline. A single 24-hour clearance window is not credible given the complexity of the Hormuz seabed, the potential for mixed mine types, and the requirement for third-party verification. The following phased clearance sequence replaces any fixed-date assumption with a verified, zone-by-zone approach. All operations proceed under the authority of the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) and the International Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships (MARPOL).

The framework architecture treats Hormuz not as a fully reopened strait but as a temporary defended corridor: a narrow, defensible passage where escort, surveillance, and defense concentrate to make transit governable rather than promising full demilitarization. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

3.1 Mine Clearance Phase I: Corridor Survey (Days 3-5)

The framework architecture establishes a phased mine clearance operation under coordination of the UN Mine Action Service (UNMAS), the Combined Maritime Forces (CMF), or another mutually accepted technical body:

- The Islamic Republic of Iran declares the locations of all known minefields, submerged obstacles, and navigation hazards within the commercial transit corridor within 48 hours of signature. This declaration goes to UNMAS and the IMO simultaneously.
- A UNMAS-led technical survey team, comprising neutral naval mine countermeasures assets from CMF partner nations under Omani coordination, enters the Strait on Day 3 to conduct a comprehensive hydrographic survey of Zone A, the primary northbound transit lane.
- Zone A extends from the Strait entrance at 25.9N 56.4E (Waypoint HOR-A1) to 26.3N 56.3E (Waypoint HOR-A2) to 26.8N 56.2E (Waypoint HOR-A3) to the Iranian port of

Bandar Abbas approach at 27.1N 56.2E (Waypoint HOR-A4), covering the highest-traffic corridor.

- The survey team employs side-scan sonar, remotely operated vehicles (ROVs), and neutralization-class drones to map all contacts. Survey data transmits in real time to both Parties and the Joint Commission.
- The United States simultaneously lifts the naval blockade of Iranian ports for humanitarian and pre-cleared commercial traffic during the survey period.

3.2 Mine Clearance Phase II: Neutralization and Verification (Days 6-10)

The framework architecture proceeds to active clearance only after survey completion:

- Upon completion of the Zone A survey, UNMAS mine countermeasures vessels neutralize or remove all identified contacts. Disposition of each contact (mine, debris, geological) is logged and transmitted to both Parties.
- Zone B, the southbound transit lane, extends from Waypoint HOR-B1 (25.8N 56.5E) through HOR-B2 (26.2N 56.4E) and HOR-B3 (26.7N 56.3E) to HOR-B4 (27.0N 56.3E). Zone B undergoes identical survey-and-clearance operations commencing on Day 6, contingent on satisfactory progress in Zone A.
- Zone C, the secondary route east of Qeshm Island used by smaller coastal traffic, extends from Waypoint HOR-C1 (26.0N 56.6E) to HOR-C2 (26.5N 56.5E) to HOR-C3 (26.9N 56.4E). Zone C undergoes survey commencing on Day 8.

3.3 Maritime Reopening and Certification (Days 11-14)

The framework architecture reopens each zone to commercial transit only after complete third-party verification:

- UNMAS, or another mutually accepted technical body, certifies each zone independently. A zone certifies as clear only when the survey team confirms that all mine-like contacts are resolved, no remaining mine-like objects are present, and a second-pass verification sweep is complete.
- The IMO issues a Maritime Safety Information (MSI) broadcast for each certified zone, notifying all shipping that the zone is open to unrestricted transit under UNCLOS and MARPOL protections.
- Lloyd's Joint War Committee receives the UNMAS certification simultaneously and convenes within 10 business days to issue revised war risk advisory ratings for the reopened zones.

- Commercial traffic resumes progressively: Zone A reopens on Day 11 upon certification; Zone B on Day 12; Zone C on Day 14. No zone reopens before its certification completes. A failure in one zone does not suspend operations in certified zones.

3.4 Temporary Transit Rules During Clearance

The framework architecture establishes temporary operational rules for vessels transiting during the clearance period:

- Commercial vessels move through the defended corridor in scheduled convoys rather than independent transit. Convoys depart at fixed intervals (every 6 hours) under Omani Royal Navy or CMF escort coordination. Escort vessels rotate every 48 hours to prevent crew fatigue and maintain neutrality. No single vessel provides escort for more than two consecutive convoy cycles. The Joint Commission maintains a published escort rotation schedule accessible to both Parties and to vessel operators through the IMO GISIS platform.
- All convoy transit occurs during daylight hours only (sunrise to sunset local time). No commercial vessel transits the corridor at night until all three zones achieve UNMAS certification.
- The Joint Commission limits convoy speed to 12 knots maximum through the narrowest section of the Strait (between Waypoints HOR-A2 and HOR-A3).
- Each convoy includes a minimum of 2 vessels and a maximum of 8 vessels. Convoy composition and timing are published 24 hours in advance through the IMO GISIS platform.
- Tug escort is available on request for vessels carrying hazardous cargo or vessels with limited maneuverability. Tug costs are shared through the Maritime Economic Confidence Fund.
- Vessels with AIS disabled or non-functional do not join convoys until AIS is restored or the vessel receives a manual tracking assignment from UKMTO.
- Alternate Routing: If UNMAS has certified only Zone A (northbound lane), southbound vessels alternate through the certified northbound lane in reverse-direction convoys supervised by the Omani Royal Navy. The IMO publishes alternate routing directives through GISIS within 6 hours of partial certification.
- Temporary Anchorage Zones: Two temporary anchorage zones operate during the clearance period: Anchorage Alpha at 26.0N 56.6E (east of the primary corridor) and Anchorage Bravo at 26.8N 56.4E (northeast of Qeshm Island). Vessels awaiting convoy assignment, vessels with mechanical issues, and vessels requiring inspection hold in these anchorages. Both anchorages sit outside the active clearance zones and are protected under the humanitarian corridor provisions.

- **Holding Patterns:** Vessels arriving at the Strait before their assigned convoy slot enter a holding pattern at designated waypoints: HOR-HOLD-1 (25.6N 56.8E) for northbound traffic and HOR-HOLD-2 (27.2N 56.0E) for southbound traffic. Holding vessels maintain station-keeping at slow speed (5 knots maximum) and remain under continuous AIS monitoring by UKMTO.
- **Salvage and Tow Priority:** If a vessel sustains damage during transit, the neutral salvage protocol activates. The nearest available tug from the Omani commercial fleet or a pre-positioned CMF support vessel provides immediate assistance. Liability for salvage operations falls under the International Convention on Salvage (1989), with costs shared through the Maritime Economic Confidence Fund if no responsible party is identified within 30 days.
- **AIS Spoofing Detection:** AIS spoofing, false identity signals, and ghost vessels constitute a severe threat to corridor safety. The Joint Commission maintains continuous AIS spoofing detection through: cross-referencing AIS data against SAR satellite imagery (the system flags any vessel whose broadcast AIS identity does not correspond to a physically detected hull); analyzing AIS signal anomalies including impossible position jumps, duplicate MMSI codes, and transmission timing irregularities; and correlating vessel declarations with IMO registry databases.
- **AIS spoofing detected within the Hormuz transit corridor** constitutes an automatic Category B disruption unless the Joint Commission attributes the spoofing to a third party within 48 hours. If attributed to a third party, the incident follows the false-flag architecture of Article 6.6. If attributed to either Party, the incident follows the graduated response framework of Article 6.4 or Article 6.5 as applicable.

3.5 Southern-Shore Defensive Node

The framework architecture establishes a small but visible defensive presence on the southern shore of the strait:

- The Sultanate of Oman hosts a joint defensive coordination cell at Ras al-Hadd, comprising Omani coastal defense personnel, UKMTO liaison officers, and neutral technical advisors.
- The node provides persistent coastal radar coverage, counter-UAS detection, and communication relay for convoy coordination. The node operates under Omani national command with technical support from CMF partner nations.
- The node demonstrates coalition commitment to safe transit without constituting a military threat to Iranian territory. The node does not host offensive weapons systems.
- Iran receives advance notification of all node personnel movements and equipment deliveries through the Joint Commission.

3.6 Contingency: Delayed Clearance

If UNMAS, or another mutually accepted technical body, certifies that clearance requires more than 14 days due to the density of contacts, the Parties agree to the following:

- The Joint Commission convenes an emergency session within 24 hours of the delay notification.
- The Joint Commission possesses automatic authority to grant one 7-day extension to the clearance timeline without requiring renegotiation of the Protocol.
- Both Parties extend the maritime standstill for the duration of the delay, up to a maximum of 21 days total.
- The humanitarian corridor remains open and protected throughout any extension.
- The United States maintains suspension of sanctions enforcement on humanitarian vessels during the extension period.

3.7 Non-Interference With Certified Zones

The framework architecture protects the integrity of UNMAS-certified zones. A certified zone represents a verified safe transit area. Any unauthorized military entry into a certified zone undermines the certification and threatens commercial confidence.

- Neither Party enters a certified zone with military vessels, military aircraft, or military personnel except under the following conditions: escort operations coordinated through the Omani Royal Navy; emergency response to a maritime distress incident; or hot pursuit of a non-Party vessel engaged in hostile action, with immediate notification to the Joint Commission.
- Any unauthorized military entry into a certified zone by either Party constitutes a Category B disruption. The Joint Commission convenes within 6 hours of any such entry and determines whether the entry was justified under the exceptions above.
- If the Joint Commission determines that the entry was not justified, the affected zone loses its certification until UNMAS completes a re-certification sweep. During the suspension of certification, convoy operations reroute through the nearest certified zone or hold at the temporary anchorage points defined in Article 3.4.
- Both Parties notify the Joint Commission 48 hours in advance of any planned military transit through a certified zone that falls within the scope of the permitted exceptions.

3.8 Neutral Salvage and Tow Authority

The framework architecture establishes a neutral salvage and tow mechanism for vessels damaged during mine clearance, convoy transit, or other Protocol operations. Salvage

operations require clear authority rules, priority procedures, and liability protection to ensure rapid response without political complication.

- The ICRC and the IMO jointly designate a Neutral Salvage Coordinator who assigns salvage priority, dispatches available tugs, and coordinates with coastal authorities. The Coordinator operates from the UKMTO Centre in Dubai with direct communication links to the Joint Commission.
- Salvage Priority Rules: (1) vessels with casualties or personnel injury receive immediate priority; (2) vessels carrying hazardous cargo receive second priority; (3) vessels blocking a transit lane receive third priority; (4) all other damaged vessels receive fourth priority.
- Liability Protection: Salvage operators, tug crews, and neutral coordinators enjoy sovereign immunity from claims arising from Protocol-authorized salvage operations. The Maritime Economic Confidence Fund provides a \$10 million salvage operations reserve to cover costs where no responsible party is identified within 30 days. If a responsible Party is identified through the Joint Attribution Panel, that Party reimburses the Fund within 90 days.
- Neither Party interferes with, delays, or boards salvage vessels operating under the Neutral Salvage Coordinator's authority. Salvage vessels operate under the same humanitarian corridor protections as ICRC and WFP vessels.

Article 4: Stabilization Protocol (Days 14-60)

Upon certification of all clearance zones, the Parties transition to the 60-day Stabilization Protocol. This extended timeline aligns with the Islamabad MOU's 60-day comprehensive negotiation window. This phase establishes verified reciprocal motion that prevents reversion to hostilities and creates the conditions for comprehensive settlement. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

4.1 Synchronized Reciprocal Motion Engine

The Synchronized Reciprocal Motion Engine governs all obligations during the Stabilization Protocol. Every Iranian commitment triggers a corresponding United States commitment on the same clock cycle. No Party moves first. No Party moves alone.

The engine operates through 24-hour verification cycles. The Joint Commission confirms that both Parties have executed their paired obligations before either obligation takes effect. If either Party fails to execute, the paired obligation suspends until both execute.

4.2 Hormuz Defended Corridor Normalization

The framework architecture normalizes the temporary defended corridor through Hormuz through the following synchronized sequence:

Phase I (Days 14-21): The Islamic Republic of Iran withdraws all IRGC-Navy and Artesh Navy small craft, patrol boats, and fast attack craft to positions beyond five nautical miles of the transit corridor. The United States simultaneously withdraws all carrier strike group assets to positions beyond fifty nautical miles of the Strait entrance.

Phase II (Days 22-35): Full commercial transit normalizes under the convoy system. The IMO certifies unobstructed passage through all three zones. The United States and Iran jointly issue a Notice to Mariners confirming safe transit under UNCLOS Article 44. Convoy frequency increases to every 4 hours. Daylight-only restrictions lift upon IMO certification of 14 consecutive days of incident-free transit.

Phase III (Days 36-60): Sustained compliance monitoring continues. The Joint Commission reviews daily compliance reports. Both Parties prepare for transition to the comprehensive framework under the Islamabad MOU.

4.3 Oil Export Waiver: Milestone-Contingent, Not Date-Fixed

The framework architecture ties any restoration of the oil export waiver to verified maritime milestones, not a fixed calendar date:

- The United States restores the sanctions waiver for Iranian crude exports up to 1.0 million barrels per day only after the Joint Commission confirms that Iran has maintained the maritime standstill for 14 consecutive days and the IMO certifies unobstructed commercial passage through all three zones.
- The waiver expands from 1.0 million barrels per day to 1.3 million barrels per day only after the Joint Commission confirms 30 consecutive days of unobstructed commercial passage and full proxy stand-down under Article 7.
- If Brent crude spikes above \$115 per barrel, the oil export ceiling automatically expands from 1.0 million barrels per day to 1.3 million barrels per day. This trigger activates automatically and requires no diplomatic renegotiation.
- If Iran breaches the maritime standstill, the proxy stand-down, or the cessation of hostile operations, the United States suspends the waiver within 72 hours of Joint Commission confirmation. Suspension follows the graduated response system described in Article 6.
- The Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) issues the waiver through its standard statutory process. Article 10 of this Protocol acknowledges the required procedural steps and the 30 business day execution timeline.

4.4 Maritime Economic Confidence Fund

The framework architecture establishes a \$250 million Maritime Economic Confidence Fund as a reciprocal goodwill deposit for insurance stabilization, port rehabilitation, and compensation for vessels damaged during the crisis:

- The United States deposits \$125 million into the Fund within 10 business days of Protocol signature. The Islamic Republic of Iran deposits \$125 million into the Fund within the same 10-business-day window.
- The Fund domiciles at a Swiss-regulated commercial bank under joint oversight of the Parties and the UN Secretary-General's office.
- The Fund releases in tranches tied to verified maritime milestones: 20% upon standstill initiation; 30% upon Zone A certification; 25% upon full reopening; 25% upon completion of the 60-day Stabilization Protocol.
- Fund disbursements cover: political risk insurance subsidies through the DFC; compensation for tankers damaged in the 7 July 2026 incidents; port infrastructure repairs at Bandar Abbas and affiliated facilities; and Lloyd's market stabilization payments.
- Either Party proposes a voluntary expansion of the Fund at any time. Expansion requires mutual agreement and deposits the additional amount within 10 business days of agreement.

4.5 Iran's Hormuz Management Role

The framework architecture recognizes Iran's established role in managing Hormuz transit and creates a joint management structure:

- The Joint Hormuz Management Board comprises two representatives from each Party, two Omani representatives, and one IMO technical advisor. The Board seats in Bandar Abbas with a liaison office in Muscat.
- The Board coordinates convoy scheduling, transit fee administration, vessel traffic management, and incident response. Iran retains primary operational authority within Iranian territorial waters; the Board provides coordination and transparency.
- Transit fees, if levied, apply equally to all flagged vessels and fund corridor maintenance, navigation aids, and environmental monitoring. Fee levels require Board consensus.
- The Board publishes monthly transit statistics, fee revenue data, and incident reports through the IMO.

4.6 Shipping Industry Working Group

The framework architecture creates a Shipping Industry Working Group to advise the Joint Commission on commercial viability:

- The Working Group comprises representatives of Lloyd's of London, the International Group of P&I Clubs, the Baltic Exchange, major shipping companies (Maersk, MSC, COSCO), and port operators from Bandar Abbas, Fujairah, and Sohar.
- The Working Group meets every 14 days during the Stabilization Protocol and advises the Joint Commission on insurance conditions, routing safety, port capacity, and commercial confidence.
- The Working Group has no decision authority but its recommendations carry procedural weight: if the Working Group advises that commercial conditions are not viable, the Joint Commission convenes within 48 hours to review.

4.7 Escalation Buffer

The framework architecture incorporates a mandatory escalation buffer that prevents heat-of-the-moment decisions from collapsing the Protocol:

- Any Party that detects a deviation reports it to the Joint Commission through the Deconfliction Hotline, not through public statements or military retaliation.
- A mandatory 48-hour cooling-off period applies to all reported deviations, disruptions, or violations. No penalties accrue during this period. No benefit reduction, waiver suspension, or escrow freeze takes effect. Both Parties' senior officials consult directly to determine whether the reported event constitutes a deviation, a disruption, a deliberate violation, a technical error, or a force majeure event.
- The cooling-off period extends to 72 hours by mutual agreement of both Parties' senior representatives. The extension requires written notification to the Joint Commission before the original 48-hour period expires.
- The escalation buffer activates automatically on detection of any kinetic incident in the Strait. Both Parties suspend all naval operations within the buffer zone for the duration of the investigation.
- Article 6 of this Protocol provides the full earn-back framework and false-flag architecture that prevents third parties from collapsing the architecture by staging incidents.

Article 5: Verification and Classification Architecture

The verification architecture ensures that every obligation is observable, measurable, and enforceable through graduated, reversible responses. No event triggers automatic collapse. Every response is proportional, reversible on remediation, and subject to human review. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

5.1 The Three-Category Classification System

The framework architecture replaces binary breach-or-compliance language with a three-category classification system. Language shapes diplomatic behavior. The shift from accusation to assessment preserves the Protocol through periods of friction.

Category A: Deviation

Behavior drifts from the expected pattern. No penalty attaches. No accusation issues. No violation is alleged. The event triggers recalibration dialogue through Article 5A.

Examples include: concentration of naval positions without new deployment; brief AIS signal gaps with innocent explanation; reporting delays up to 24 hours; minor positioning variances; temporary increases in patrol frequency that do not cross the new-deployment threshold; ISR activity slightly above baseline; and cyber scanning activity without intrusion.

Category B: Disruption

Behavior interferes with Protocol implementation. The event triggers Tier 2 review under Article 6. Humanitarian flows remain protected.

Examples include: access denial fewer than 72 hours; unauthorized naval incursions into the standstill zone; cyber disruption of navigation or port systems for fewer than 4 hours; proxy maritime harassment that does not result in vessel damage; and failure to respond to three consecutive Hotline calls within 30 minutes.

Category C: Deliberate Violation

Intentional hostile conduct directed at undermining the Protocol. The event triggers Tier 3 review under Article 6.

Examples include: attacks on inspectors or neutral observers; deliberate naval aggression against commercial vessels; proxy attacks directed or knowingly facilitated by a Party; deliberate cyberattacks on critical infrastructure causing operational shutdown; and placement of new mines or obstacles in a certified-clear zone.

5.2 The Joint Commission

The Joint Commission serves as the single political and compliance body for this Protocol, consistent with the Islamabad MOU's established governance structure:

- The Commission seats in Muscat, Sultanate of Oman, and comprises two senior representatives from each Party plus the Omani facilitator, a representative of the State of Qatar, a representative of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan, and a representative of the UN Secretary-General's office.
- For political questions (waivers, sanctions, strategic decisions), the Commission operates by consensus. For technical questions (certification, verification, timeline adjustments), the Commission operates by supermajority: four of five votes, with the UN Secretary-General's representative casting the tiebreaker if needed. The Omani facilitator votes on procedural questions only.
- The Commission convenes within four hours of any reported Category B or Category C event, within 24 hours of any Category A deviation, and within 24 hours of any technical dispute. The Commission holds scheduled sessions every 72 hours during the Stabilization Protocol.
- The Commission possesses automatic authority to grant one 7-day extension to any Protocol timeline without requiring renegotiation. This authority prevents procedural delays from becoming political crises.
- The Commission publishes a weekly compliance report accessible to both Parties and the international community through the UN Secretary-General's office, indicating the status of every obligation under this Protocol.
- Either Party refers an unresolved dispute to the UN Secretary-General for final resolution through the Secretary-General's good offices. The Secretary-General appoints a special envoy if direct facilitation proves insufficient.
- During a leadership transition or succession period in either Party, the Joint Commission's quorum for technical decisions is reduced from four of five votes to three of five votes for a period of 60 days following the activation of a succession mechanism. This temporary quorum reduction prevents deadlock during a period when one Party's senior representatives experience unavailability due to transition-related demands. The quorum reduction expires automatically on day 61, or earlier upon mutual agreement of both Parties.

5.2A Quantitative Tolerance Bands

The Joint Commission applies the following quantitative tolerance bands for maritime and airspace activity verification. These bands provide operational flexibility while maintaining accountability:

- Temporal tolerance: plus or minus 20% of scheduled transit or patrol timelines. A convoy departing 15 minutes early or a patrol extending 20% beyond its scheduled duration does not trigger classification.
- Spatial tolerance: zero tolerance for coordinate deviations. Any deviation from agreed transit lanes, patrol sectors, or standstill zone boundaries triggers automatic flagging. The corridor is narrow; spatial discipline is non-negotiable.
- Quantitative tolerance: plus or minus 5% of reported vessel counts, patrol frequencies, or cargo volumes. A patrol frequency 4% above baseline does not trigger classification. A patrol frequency 6% above baseline triggers an automatic flag.
- Qualitative tolerance: zero tolerance for operational specification deviations. Any deviation from agreed operational parameters including vessel types, aircraft configurations, weapons status, or communication protocols triggers automatic flagging.
- The Joint Commission adjusts these bands by supermajority vote upon demonstrated operational necessity. Adjustments are prospective only and apply no earlier than 48 hours after the Commission's vote.

5.2B Automated Flagging Engine

The Joint Commission maintains an automated flagging engine that continuously scans all telemetry against the expected patterns recorded in the Protocol and its annexes. Divergence beyond agreed tolerance bands generates an automatic alert to both Parties and the Joint Commission within 15 minutes of detection.

- The automated flagging engine serves an informational and early-warning function only. No automatic penalty or benefit reduction attaches to any automated flag. Every flag triggers human review.
- The engine integrates data from: AIS transponders; SAR satellite imagery; optical satellite imagery; coastal radar feeds from the Omani Royal Navy; air traffic control data from the Omani coordination cell; and cyber activity monitors.
- The engine generates three alert levels: Yellow (Category A threshold exceeded, triggers recalibration dialogue under Article 5A); Orange (Category B threshold exceeded, triggers Joint Commission convening within 4 hours); and Red (Category C threshold exceeded, triggers immediate Joint Commission emergency session and Shock Protocol standby under Article 5B).
- The Joint Commission conducts an annual technical audit of the automated flagging engine to verify accuracy, calibration, and absence of systematic bias. The audit report is available to both Parties.

5.3 Multi-Sensor Fusion Verification Standard

The framework architecture requires multi-sensor fusion for all maritime verification. No single sensor constitutes sufficient evidence:

- AIS transponder data provides the primary vessel identification layer. However, AIS is vulnerable to spoofing and disablement. AIS data alone never constitutes conclusive evidence.
- Synthetic aperture radar (SAR) satellite imagery from commercial providers confirms vessel presence and movement regardless of AIS status. SAR operates in all weather conditions and detects vessels that have disabled transponders.
- High-resolution optical satellite imagery provides visual confirmation of vessel type, configuration, and activity. Optical imagery resolves identification questions that AIS and SAR cannot answer.
- Neutral naval observers from the Omani Royal Navy, deployed on coastal stations and patrol vessels, provide human eyewitness confirmation and real-time radio reporting.
- The Joint Commission classifies an event only when at least two independent sensor categories corroborate the same finding. A single-source report triggers investigation but does not, by itself, support a classification.
- Sensor Blind Spot Compensation: If two sensors disagree on a detection or classification, the third available sensor category serves as the tie-breaker. The tie-breaker sensor is the one whose operational characteristics are most suited to resolve the specific discrepancy: for identity disputes, optical imagery takes precedence; for presence disputes in adverse weather, SAR takes precedence; for real-time movement disputes, coastal radar takes precedence; for communication disputes, the Omani Royal Navy observer report takes precedence. If the third sensor is unavailable due to outage, weather, or technical failure, the event receives a Category A classification pending sensor restoration and re-evaluation.

5.4 Cyber Incident Verification

The framework architecture establishes specific rules for cyber incident verification and classification. Cyber activity constitutes one of the most likely triggers for misinterpretation in Hormuz. This section closes that gap.

- Either Party reports a suspected cyber disruption to the Joint Commission within 2 hours of detection. The Commission convenes its cyber review subcommittee within 6 hours.
- The cyber review subcommittee comprises one technical expert from each Party and one neutral forensic specialist appointed by the UN Secretary-General.
- Attribution of a cyber incident requires at least two independent forensic indicators from the following categories: malware signature analysis linking the attack to known Party-

affiliated tools; network traffic analysis tracing command-and-control infrastructure to Party-controlled IP ranges or autonomous systems; forensic examination of compromised systems revealing attacker methodology consistent with documented Party capabilities; or human intelligence from a source the subcommittee independently assesses as reliable. IP geolocation alone is insufficient for attribution.

- The subcommittee completes its forensic review within 48 hours and issues a preliminary classification: Category A (minor deviation with no intent), Category B (material disruption with unclear attribution), or Category C (deliberate attack with clear attribution).
- Cyber incidents map to the three-category system as follows: Category A cyber incidents (unintentional scanning, minor service degradation, brief firewall alerts) receive technical assistance and do not trigger benefit reduction. Category B cyber incidents (disruption of navigation or port systems for fewer than 4 hours, unauthorized system probing with evidence of intent) trigger a 14-day resolution window. Category C cyber incidents (deliberate attacks on critical infrastructure causing operational shutdown, destruction of navigation data, or sabotage of vessel traffic management) trigger full graduated response under Article 6.
- Both Parties commit to sharing cyber threat indicators through the Joint Commission for the duration of the Protocol. Information sharing does not require attribution and does not constitute an admission of vulnerability.

5.5 Independent Technical Review Panel

Every Category B and Category C classification requires prior review by an Independent Technical Review Panel before any response takes effect:

- The Panel comprises three senior technical experts: one nominated by each Party and one neutral expert agreed by both Parties or, in the absence of agreement, appointed by the UN Secretary-General.
- The Panel convenes within 24 hours of a Category B or Category C referral and completes its review within 48 hours. The Panel examines the technical evidence, assesses proportionality, and determines whether exceptional circumstances warrant modification or deferral of the proposed response.
- No response takes effect until the Panel completes its review. This mandatory 48-to-72-hour cooling-off period prevents politically driven overreaction to ambiguous events.
- The Panel issues a written determination with findings of fact and recommendations. The Joint Commission considers the Panel's recommendations but retains final decision authority.

5.6 Force Majeure

The framework architecture excludes force majeure events from all classification and response categories:

- "Force majeure" means natural disasters, major storms, tsunamis, earthquakes, pandemics, technical failures of monitoring equipment, satellite outages, or other events beyond the reasonable control of either Party that prevent compliance with a Protocol obligation.
- Either Party declares a force majeure event by written notification to the Joint Commission within 12 hours of the event. The Commission determines whether the event qualifies as force majeure within 24 hours.
- During a declared force majeure, all compliance deadlines extend by the duration of the force majeure plus 48 hours. No classification or response accrues during the force majeure period or the 48-hour recovery period.
- Both Parties cooperate to mitigate the effects of force majeure events on the Protocol, including sharing resources, personnel, and information where practicable.
- If a force majeure event persists for more than 14 consecutive days, either Party proposes a Protocol suspension. Suspension freezes all obligations and timelines. Restoration proceeds from the pre-suspension baseline.

Article 5A: Recalibration and Deviation Management

This Article operates on pure alignment-based principles. Its purpose is to detect dangerous behavioral drift before it becomes a disruption or violation. No penalty attaches to any action under this Article. This is preventative diplomacy, not enforcement. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

5A.1 Purpose

The Recalibration Mechanism exists to catch the following behavioral patterns before either Party begins talking about breach determinations:

- Naval posturing: unusual vessel concentrations, atypical patrol patterns, or positioning changes that suggest preparation for offensive action.
- Radar interference: electronic jamming, spoofing, or disruption of commercial or neutral monitoring radar systems.

- Unusual aircraft activity: drone flights outside established corridors, helicopter operations near commercial shipping lanes, or fixed-wing aircraft approaches within the deconflicted airspace.
- Aggressive maneuvering: close-approach tactics, simulated attack runs, or vessel intercepts that fall short of kinetic contact but create escalation risk.
- Militia chatter: open-source or signals intelligence indicating proxy group mobilization, weapons movement, or operational planning.
- ISR surges: detectable increases in intelligence-collection activity targeting the other Party's military or commercial assets.
- Excessive patrol activity: patrol frequency or duration exceeding the pre-crisis baseline without operational justification.

5A.2 Recalibration Process

Either Party identifies a concerning pattern. No accusation is made. No disruption is alleged. No violation is claimed. The Recalibration Mechanism operates through a structured dialogue process:

Step 1 — Joint Framing (within 48 hours of deviation classification): Both Alignment Officers simultaneously submit to the Joint Commission: their understanding of the deviation's cause; their proposed adjustment(s); and their implementation needs from the other Party.

Step 2 — Adjustment Mapping (within 7 days of Framing completion): The Alignment Officers jointly map adjustments into three categories: unilateral adjustments (implemented by one Party independently); mutual adjustments (requiring coordinated action by both Parties); and external adjustments (requiring third-party support).

Step 3 — Experimentation (within 30 days of Mapping completion): Both Parties implement agreed adjustments on a trial basis. The Joint Commission collects enhanced telemetry at double the standard frequency. Either Party requests early termination if unintended consequences emerge.

Step 4 — Integration or Reversion (within 14 days of Experimentation completion): Integration: If alignment restores, the adjustment becomes the new expected pattern. Reversion: If alignment does not restore, the Parties revert to prior patterns.

Recursion Limit: The same deviation follows the recalibration procedure a maximum of three complete cycles. If three cycles complete without successful integration, the deviation escalates to Tier 2 material disruption under Article 6.

5A.3 Core Principle

No penalties attach to any event processed through this Article. The Recalibration Mechanism operates entirely outside the classification and response system of Article 5. A deviation processed through Article 5A never becomes the basis for a Tier 1, Tier 2, or Tier 3 response under Article 6.

For a maritime crisis protocol, this mechanism saves more agreements than enforcement provisions. It catches escalation before either side commits to an adversarial position. It preserves diplomatic space. It prevents the accumulation of grievances that collapse frameworks.

Article 5B: Shock Event Management

This Article addresses major kinetic events, attacks resulting in casualties, or incidents that threaten to collapse the Protocol through political or public outrage. It operates independently of the standard Category A/B/C classification system and overrides normal procedural timelines during the immediate crisis window. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

5B.1 Definition of a Shock Event

A Shock Event is any incident that:

- Results in death or serious injury to military or civilian personnel of either Party or neutral third parties.
- Results in sinking, severe damage, or total loss of a military vessel, commercial vessel, or aircraft.
- Involves the detonation of explosive ordnance within the Hormuz transit corridor or Persian Gulf that causes significant structural damage.
- Involves a ballistic missile, cruise missile, or anti-ship missile launch against a military or commercial target.
- Involves a suicide drone or kamikaze UAV strike against a vessel or facility.
- Involves cyber disruption that causes the grounding, collision, or navigation failure of a commercial vessel.
- Is publicly attributed by either Party, its allies, or major media to the other Party before the Joint Commission completes its initial review.

A Shock Event is not subject to the standard 48-hour attribution deferral window. It triggers the Shock Protocol (Section 5B.3) within 1 hour of confirmation.

5B.2 Shock Event Declaration

Either Party declares a Shock Event by:

- Notifying the Joint Commission through the Deconfliction Hotline within 15 minutes of confirmation.
- Notifying the other Party through the Omani backchannel within 30 minutes of confirmation.
- Requesting immediate Shock Protocol activation from the Joint Commission.

The Joint Commission convenes in emergency session within 2 hours of any Shock Event declaration. No public statement regarding attribution, responsibility, or retaliation is issued by either Party until the Joint Commission issues its Preliminary Shock Assessment (Section 5B.4).

5B.3 The Shock Protocol — Immediate Actions (0-24 Hours)

Upon declaration of a Shock Event, the following actions activate automatically and simultaneously:

- **Automatic Standstill Extension:** The maritime standstill extends for an additional 72 hours from the hour of the Shock Event, regardless of where the original standstill period stood. Both Parties maintain existing naval positions. No reinforcements, no redeployments, no forward movements. Airspace deconfliction rules remain in full effect.
- **Casualty Evacuation Corridor:** A dedicated casualty evacuation corridor opens immediately. Medical evacuation aircraft and vessels transit without interference. The ICRC coordinates casualty evacuation and provides neutral medical assessment. Neither Party inspects, delays, or targets medical evacuation assets.
- **Forensic Freeze:** All sensor data (AIS, SAR, optical, radar, communications intercepts) from the 6 hours preceding the Shock Event through 6 hours after is preserved and transmitted to the Joint Commission. Neither Party deletes, alters, or withholds sensor data. Deletion or alteration is itself a Category C deliberate violation. Both Parties grant the Joint Attribution Panel (Article 6.7) immediate access to all raw forensic data.
- **No Retaliation Pledge:** Both Parties issue a simultaneous, identical public statement: "The Parties affirm that they do not retaliate for the pending incident pending the Joint Commission's Preliminary Shock Assessment. Both Parties remain committed to the Emergency De-escalation Protocol." Any retaliatory action during the 24-hour Shock Protocol window is itself a Category C deliberate violation.
- **Intelligence Sharing Requirement:** Both Parties share all actionable intelligence relevant to the Shock Event with the Joint Attribution Panel within 6 hours. Failure to share constitutes a Category B material disruption.

- **Media Blackout:** Neither Party briefs media, issues press releases, or conducts social media campaigns regarding the Shock Event until the Preliminary Shock Assessment is issued. Official statements are limited to: "The Parties are investigating the incident through the Joint Commission. Further information is provided when available." A public statement violating this blackout is itself a Category B material disruption.

5B.4 Preliminary Shock Assessment (24-48 Hours)

Within 48 hours of the Shock Event, the Joint Attribution Panel issues a Preliminary Shock Assessment with one of three findings:

- **Finding A — Inconclusive / Insufficient Evidence:** No Party bears responsibility. The Protocol continues in full effect. The standstill extension remains in place for an additional 48 hours while further investigation proceeds. Neither Party faces any benefit reduction.
- **Finding B — Attributed to a Third Party / Rogue Actor:** A third party, non-state actor, or rogue element is responsible. Both Parties issue a joint statement condemning the incident and affirming the Protocol remains in full effect. Neither Party retaliates against the other. Both Parties coordinate through the UN Security Council for appropriate measures against the third party. The Protocol continues without penalty.
- **Finding C — Attributed to a Party:** The evidence identifies one Party as responsible. The 48-hour cooling-off period extends to 72 hours from the Preliminary Shock Assessment. During this extended cooling-off period, senior officials from both Parties consult directly on: whether the incident was deliberate or a result of negligence; and what proportionate, graduated response is appropriate. No response takes effect during the extended cooling-off period. If the Parties agree on a mutual resolution, the Protocol continues with adjusted terms. If the Parties cannot agree, the Protocol proceeds to Section 5B.5.

5B.5 Escalation Containment (48-72 Hours)

If the Preliminary Shock Assessment attributes responsibility to a Party (Finding C) and the Parties cannot agree on a mutual resolution within the extended cooling-off period:

- **Graduated, Not Punitive, Response:** The Joint Commission, by supermajority (4 of 5), recommends a proportional graduated response under Article 6 (Tier 2 or Tier 3 as applicable). The response is not punitive in character. It is intended to restore confidence, not to punish. The response focuses on: enhanced verification requirements; temporary suspension of specific non-humanitarian benefit tranches; and increased monitoring.

- **No Unilateral Action:** Neither Party takes unilateral kinetic, diplomatic, or economic action against the other outside the Joint Commission's recommended response. Unilateral action triggers automatic Protocol suspension and invokes the Exit Ramp (Article 12).
- **Earn-Back Pathway Remains Open:** The earn-back pathway under Article 6 remains fully available. Full restoration follows the standard earn-back timelines (14 days for Tier 2; 30 days for Tier 3) plus Joint Commission certification.
- **Shock Event Review Board:** The Joint Commission establishes a Shock Event Review Board comprising senior retired military officers from neutral nations (Sweden, Switzerland, Singapore, or Japan). The Board reviews the incident, the forensic evidence, and the Panel's classification. The Board issues a non-binding report within 30 days with recommendations for preventing recurrence. Both Parties commit to implementing the Board's recommendations unless they mutually agree otherwise.

5B.6 Shock Event Pre-Agreed Response Scenarios

The Parties pre-agree the following response rules for common Shock Event scenarios, eliminating the need for negotiation during a crisis:

- **Unarmed drone overflight of a convoy, no damage:** Classification Category A. Immediate response is recalibration dialogue. No earn-back applies.
- **Armed drone strike on a commercial vessel, no casualties:** Classification Category B. Immediate response is 14-day resolution window with 30% benefit reduction. Earn-back follows 14 clean days.
- **Armed drone strike on a military vessel, casualties:** Classification Category C. Immediate response is 30-day remediation period with full suspension of non-humanitarian benefits. Earn-back follows 30 clean days plus Joint Commission certification.
- **Mine strike in a certified-clear zone, no casualties:** Classification Category B. Immediate response is 14-day resolution window with temporary closure of affected zone. Earn-back follows 14 clean days plus UNMAS recertification.
- **Mine strike in a certified-clear zone, casualties:** Classification Category C. Immediate response is 30-day remediation period with full suspension of non-humanitarian benefits. Earn-back follows 30 clean days plus UNMAS recertification plus Joint Commission certification.
- **Ballistic missile attack on military base:** Classification Category C. Immediate response is full Shock Protocol activation with full suspension. Earn-back follows 30 clean days plus Joint Commission certification.
- **Cyberattack causing vessel grounding or collision:** Classification Category C. Immediate response is full Shock Protocol activation. Earn-back follows 30 clean days plus forensic certification.

- Third-party false-flag attack with intent to collapse Protocol: Classification Finding B. Immediate response is joint statement within 6 hours affirming Protocol remains in effect. No penalty applies; the Protocol continues.

5B.7 Shock Event Communication Protocol

During any Shock Event, the following communication rules apply:

- The Deconfliction Hotline operates at ministerial level for the duration of the Shock Protocol.
- The Omani, Pakistani, and Qatari foreign ministers serve as immediate crisis communicators between the Parties.
- The UN Secretary-General receives hourly briefings and stands ready to convene an emergency UN Security Council session if requested by either Party.
- Neither Party holds press conferences regarding the Shock Event until the Preliminary Shock Assessment is issued.
- Joint statements, when issued, use only mutually agreed language and do not attribute blame.

5B.8 Shock Event Termination

The Shock Protocol terminates when:

- The Joint Attribution Panel issues its Final Shock Assessment (which affirms, modifies, or overturns the Preliminary Shock Assessment); or
- The Parties agree in writing to terminate the Shock Protocol and return to normal Protocol operations; or
- Seven days elapse from the Shock Event declaration without a Final Shock Assessment, in which case the Protocol automatically returns to normal operations with the Category A/B/C classification of the incident determined by the Joint Commission by supermajority.

5B.9 The Shock Freeze Window

The Shock Freeze Window is a narrow, strictly limited mechanism that pauses penalty activation for a brief period following a verified Category C event. It exists solely to prevent an incident from triggering a chain reaction of penalties before the Joint Commission completes its assessment. It is not a general-purpose delay mechanism. No provision of this section creates a precedent for future negotiations.

- **Freeze Activation — Category C Only:** The Shock Freeze Window activates only for events classified as Category C deliberate violations by the Joint Commission based on multi-sensor corroboration and unanimous Panel findings. The Freeze does not activate for: minor proxy attacks by unidentified groups; single drone incidents without kinetic damage; spoofed AIS signals; small-boat harassment below Category C thresholds; cyber scanning without system intrusion; or any Category A or Category B event. Only confirmed kinetic strikes, confirmed mine detonations in certified zones, confirmed major cyber outages causing operational shutdown, confirmed sabotage of critical infrastructure, or confirmed rogue-actor attacks with multi-sensor attribution qualify.
- **Freeze Activation — Neutral Confirmation Required:** The Freeze does not activate automatically upon Party declaration. The activation sequence is: incident occurs; the Joint Commission, the Omani relay, and UKMTO independently verify the incident using their respective sensor and communication channels; if all three verification sources confirm a Category C classification, the Freeze activates; if any verification source dissents or reports insufficient evidence, the Freeze does not activate and the standard Article 6 response timeline proceeds. Neither Party self-declares a Freeze.
- **Freeze Scope — Penalties Only:** The Freeze pauses only the activation of penalties, benefit reductions, waiver suspensions, and escrow freezes. It does not pause: verification activities; telemetry collection; sensor monitoring; classification proceedings; Joint Commission investigations; or forensic analysis. Verification continues at full speed during the Freeze. Telemetry continues. Classification continues. Only the penalty activation clock pauses.
- **Freeze Duration — 12 Hours, Non-Renewable:** The Shock Freeze Window lasts 12 hours from the moment of Joint Commission verification confirmation. The Freeze does not renew, extend, or repeat. At the end of 12 hours, all paused penalties activate simultaneously unless the Joint Commission issues a superseding determination.
- **Freeze Frequency Limit — Once Per 72 Hours:** The Shock Freeze Window activates a maximum of one time within any 72-hour period. If a second qualifying Category C event occurs within 72 hours of a previous Freeze activation, the second event is investigated under standard Article 6 timelines but no Freeze activates. Penalties continue normally for the second event. This rule prevents serial exploitation of the Freeze mechanism.
- **Freeze Does Not Delay Remediation Clocks:** If either Party is in an active remediation or earn-back period when a Freeze activates, the remediation clock continues running. The Freeze does not pause, extend, or reset earn-back timelines. A Party in a 14-day Tier 2 remediation period does not receive additional time because a Freeze occurred.
- **Freeze Does Not Affect Humanitarian Flows:** Humanitarian corridor operations, medical evacuation transit, ICRC and WFP vessel movements, and UN-agency operations continue without interruption during any Freeze. No Freeze delays, diverts, or suspends humanitarian transit.

- **Freeze Does Not Affect Convoy Operations:** Convoy schedules, escort rotations, clearance operations, zone certification processes, and UNMAS activities continue without interruption during any Freeze. No Freeze halts maritime reopening.
- **Freeze Cannot Be Triggered by Proxies:** A Shock Freeze Window activates only for events directly attributable to a Party through the Joint Attribution Panel's multi-sensor corroboration process, or for events conclusively attributed to a third-party rogue actor with clear intent to collapse the Protocol. Ambiguous proxy activity, unattributed small-boat harassment, or unverified third-party claims do not trigger a Freeze.
- **Freeze Triggers Mandatory Stability Review:** Within 6 hours of Freeze activation, both Parties' senior representatives meet in a stability review session chaired by the Omani facilitator. The review addresses: reaffirmation of both Parties' commitment to the Protocol; assessment of whether the incident threatens Protocol viability; identification of any immediate confidence-building measures; and agreement on accelerated communication protocols for the 72 hours following the Freeze. The stability review produces a non-binding joint statement of continued commitment. Neither Party uses the review to delay, renegotiate, or condition Protocol obligations.

Article 6: Incident Response and Earn-Back Framework

This Article replaces traditional penalty frameworks with a graduated-response architecture: every response is proportional, every reduction is reversible, and every pathway leads back to compliance. The framework rejects binary punishment logic, automatic escalation, and implied "one strike and collapse" provisions. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

6.1 Response Architecture Overview

The incident response sequence follows this order for all classified events:

Incident → Attribution Deferral → Classification → Proportional Response → Earn-Back Pathway → Restoration

No response is automatic. No classification triggers predetermined penalties. Every step requires human decision. Every reduction is reversible.

6.1A Good Faith Presumption

The Parties operate under a presumption of good faith throughout all compliance and incident response procedures. This presumption applies to: automated flag interpretation; classification

decisions; attribution determinations; recalibration dialogue participation; and earn-back compliance verification.

- The presumption is rebutted only by clear and convincing evidence that a Party deliberately acted to undermine the Protocol.
- A pattern of ambiguous events does not, by itself, rebut the presumption. Attribution requires evidence, not inference.
- The Independent Technical Review Panel evaluates all evidence against the good faith presumption before issuing any Tier 2 or Tier 3 determination. The Panel's written findings explicitly address whether the evidence overcomes the presumption.
- Neither Party cites a series of Category A deviations as evidence of systemic non-compliance. Each event is assessed on its individual merits.

6.2 Attribution Deferral Window

The framework architecture mandates a minimum 48-hour attribution deferral window for all Category B and Category C events. During this window:

- Neither Party retaliates. No kinetic response. No cyber counterstrike. No diplomatic sanction.
- Neither Party imposes a penalty. No benefit reduction. No waiver suspension. No escrow freeze.
- Neither Party escalates. No public accusation. No media briefing. No social media campaign.
- Both Parties engage exclusively in evidence collection: forensic review, sensor data analysis, communications intercept assessment, and human intelligence evaluation.
- The Joint Commission meets every 12 hours during the deferral window to review new evidence and assess whether the situation warrants an extension.

This provision alone saves the agreement from a single tanker incident. The 48-hour pause prevents the first 48 minutes from deciding the fate of the Protocol.

6.2A Cyber Forensics and Attribution Standards

The framework architecture establishes specific rules for cyber incident investigation, evidence thresholds, and classification mapping. Cyber incidents require specialized handling distinct from kinetic incidents.

- Investigation Authority: The cyber review subcommittee of the Joint Commission (Article 5.4) serves as the sole investigating body for cyber incidents. The subcommittee comprises one technical expert from each Party and one neutral forensic specialist

appointed by the UN Secretary-General. No Party conducts unilateral cyber forensics and presents findings to the other Party.

- **Evidence Thresholds:** Attribution of a cyber incident requires at least two independent forensic indicators from: malware signature analysis linking the attack to known Party-affiliated tools; network traffic analysis tracing command-and-control infrastructure to Party-controlled IP ranges or autonomous systems; forensic examination of compromised systems revealing attacker methodology consistent with documented Party capabilities; or human intelligence from a source the subcommittee independently assesses as reliable. IP geolocation alone is insufficient.
- **Category A/B/C Mapping for Cyber Incidents:** Category A cyber incidents (unintentional scanning, minor service degradation, brief firewall alerts, misconfigured security tools generating false positives) receive confidential technical assistance. No benefit reduction occurs. Category B cyber incidents (disruption of navigation or port systems for fewer than 4 hours, unauthorized system probing with evidence of intent, data exfiltration without system destruction) trigger a 14-day resolution window under Tier 2. Category C cyber incidents (deliberate attacks on critical infrastructure causing operational shutdown, destruction of navigation data, sabotage of vessel traffic management, ransomware deployment affecting port operations) trigger full graduated response under Tier 3.
- **Earn-Back Interaction for Cyber Incidents:** The earn-back pathway for cyber incidents follows the standard Article 6 timelines. A Party demonstrates corrective action by: patching the exploited vulnerability; sharing the technical fix with the Joint Commission; submitting to a follow-on penetration test by the neutral forensic specialist; and maintaining 14 consecutive days (Tier 2) or 30 consecutive days (Tier 3) of clean cyber activity as verified by the automated flagging engine.
- **False-Flag Protection for Cyber:** The subcommittee applies the same corroboration standard as kinetic incidents (Article 6.6). A cyber incident attributed to a third party through the false-flag architecture does not trigger any benefit reduction. Both Parties share cyber threat indicators regardless of attribution.
- **Forensic Indicator Categories:** The subcommittee evaluates the following forensic indicator categories for all cyber incidents: network traffic logs showing command-and-control communication patterns; malware hash comparisons against known Party-affiliated threat actor libraries; disk forensic images revealing persistence mechanisms and attacker tooling; memory dumps showing live attacker processes or injected code; firewall and IDS/IPS logs documenting the attack chain; and DNS query logs tracing domain resolution to known malicious infrastructure.
- **Attribution Timeline:** The cyber attribution timeline follows these fixed deadlines: T+0 hours — Detection and initial reporting to the Joint Commission; T+2 hours — Subcommittee convenes and begins evidence collection; T+6 hours — Preliminary forensic analysis complete; T+24 hours — Initial indicator correlation against known

threat libraries; T+48 hours — Subcommittee issues preliminary classification (Category A, B, or C); T+72 hours — Independent Technical Review Panel validates or challenges the classification; T+96 hours — Joint Commission issues final classification determination. No classification takes effect before T+72 hours.

- Cyber-to-Category Mapping Summary: Unintentional scanning and brief firewall alerts map to Category A with confidential technical assistance. Disruption of navigation or port systems for fewer than 4 hours maps to Category B with a 14-day resolution window. Deliberate attacks causing operational shutdown map to Category C with full graduated response. Ransomware, data destruction, or sabotage of vessel traffic management always maps to Category C regardless of duration.

6.3 Tier 1: Technical Event

Tier 1 covers minor operational deviations with plausible explanations. No benefit reduction occurs. The response is entirely technical:

- The Joint Commission provides confidential technical assistance to the Party whose assets generated the deviation.
- The Commission adjusts monitoring parameters to account for the deviation's signature.
- The Commission documents the event in its advisory log but does not include it in the public compliance report.
- The Tier 1 response requires no earn-back because no benefit was reduced.

Examples include: deviation reporting at 0.3% above baseline for fewer than 48 hours; minor patrol positioning variances; temporary AIS gaps with equipment malfunction explanation; and brief cyber scanning without system intrusion.

6.4 Tier 2: Material Disruption

Tier 2 covers substantive events that interfere with Protocol implementation. The response is graduated and reversible:

- The Joint Commission issues a formal finding of material disruption. The finding specifies the nature of the disruption, the evidence supporting the classification, and the recommended proportional response.
- Humanitarian flows remain fully protected. No Tier 2 response affects medical supplies, food shipments, disaster relief, or UN agency operations.
- The proportional response includes: suspension of non-humanitarian benefit tranches; delay of scheduled waiver expansions; temporary restriction of convoy frequency increases; or enhanced verification requirements for the affected obligation.

- A 14-day resolution window opens. During this window, the affected Party demonstrates corrective action.
- Full earn-back follows 14 consecutive clean days plus Joint Commission certification that the corrective measures are operational and effective.
- Earn-Back Acceleration: If the affected Party demonstrates over-compliance (performance exceeding baseline requirements by 20% or more during the remediation period), the earn-back monitoring period reduces by up to 25%. Tier 2 earn-back becomes minimum 11 days instead of 14. Over-compliance includes: patrol frequency below 90% of baseline; enhanced sensor cooperation beyond standard requirements; proactive Joint Commission briefings on corrective measures; and voluntary third-party verification of corrective systems.

Earn-back does not require: admission of fault, payment of penalties, or political concessions.

Earn-back does require: verified compliance with the breached obligation; sustained compliance for the defined monitoring period; and Joint Commission certification.

Examples include: access denial to neutral observers for fewer than 72 hours; unauthorized naval incursions into the standstill zone; cyber disruption of navigation systems for fewer than 4 hours; and proxy maritime harassment without vessel damage.

6.5 Tier 3: Deliberate Hostile Violation

Tier 3 covers conscious, informed conduct intended to undermine the Protocol. The response is the maximum graduated response, but it remains reversible:

- The Independent Technical Review Panel confirms by unanimous written finding that the conduct was deliberate, informed, and hostile. No single Panel member triggers a Tier 3 response alone.
- Humanitarian flows remain fully protected. No Tier 3 response affects medical supplies, food shipments, disaster relief, or UN agency operations.
- The proportional response includes: full suspension of non-humanitarian benefits; reversal of previously granted waiver expansions; suspension of escrow releases; and enhanced multi-sensor verification of all obligations.
- A 30-day remediation period opens. During this period, the affected Party demonstrates credible corrective measures and commits to preventing recurrence.
- Full earn-back follows 30 clean days plus Joint Commission majority confirmation and an affirmative finding that the violating Party has taken credible corrective measures.
- Earn-Back Acceleration: If the affected Party demonstrates over-compliance (performance exceeding baseline requirements by 20% or more during the remediation period), the earn-back monitoring period reduces by up to 25%. Tier 3 earn-back becomes minimum 23 days instead of 30.

- If the same Party triggers Tier 3 twice within 60 days, the Joint Commission convenes an emergency review to assess whether the Protocol remains viable. Viability requires both Parties to affirm continued commitment.

Examples include: attacks on inspectors or neutral observers; deliberate naval aggression against commercial vessels; proxy attacks directed or knowingly facilitated by a Party; deliberate cyberattacks causing operational shutdown; and placement of new obstacles in certified-clear zones.

6.6 False-Flag Architecture

The framework architecture acknowledges that third parties stage incidents to collapse the Protocol. The following safeguards prevent false-flag events from triggering automatic escalation:

- Attribution requires corroboration from at least two independent sensor categories plus at least one additional evidence type: intercepted communications, recovered material evidence, or independently assessed human intelligence.
- The 48-hour attribution deferral window applies to all events regardless of apparent clarity. Even events that appear unambiguously attributable undergo the full deferral process.
- The Joint Attribution Panel, described in Article 6.7, maintains exclusive authority to classify events. No Party unilaterally classifies an event, even when the evidence appears overwhelming.
- If the Panel classifies an event as "Attributed to Third Party / Rogue Actor," both Parties issue a joint statement within six hours affirming that the Protocol remains in full effect. Neither Party exploits the incident to justify unilateral action.
- Both Parties commit to independently investigating any links between the third party and their own security services. Each Party reports its findings to the Joint Commission within 14 days. If credible evidence emerges that one Party directed or knowingly facilitated the third-party attack, the incident reclassifies as Tier 3.

6.7 Joint Attribution Panel

The framework architecture creates a Joint Attribution Panel with sole authority to classify events and recommend responses:

- The Panel comprises two senior intelligence analysts from each Party, two representatives of the Omani security services, one representative of the Pakistani intelligence services, and one senior investigator from the UN Office of Counter-Terrorism.

- The Panel convenes within six hours of any kinetic incident in the Strait of Hormuz, the Persian Gulf, or the Gulf of Oman that either Party reports as a potential Protocol concern.
- The Panel classifies each incident into one of four categories: Attributed to Party A; Attributed to Party B; Attributed to Third Party / Rogue Actor; or Inconclusive. An Inconclusive finding means no Party bears responsibility and the event does not affect Protocol compliance.
- No Party imposes a response or publicly declares the other Party in breach until the Panel issues its classification. Public declarations made before Panel review are themselves Category A deviations.

6.7A Joint Fact-Finding for Inconclusive Classifications

If the Panel classifies an incident as Inconclusive, the following Joint Fact-Finding pathway activates:

- The Panel defines the specific information gaps preventing attribution within 48 hours of the Inconclusive determination.
- Both Parties commit to providing all requested information within 14 days of the Panel's request.
- If information remains insufficient after the 14-day period, the Panel commissions an independent technical assessment from a neutral expert jointly selected by the Parties or, in the absence of agreement, appointed by the UN Secretary-General.
- The independent assessment produces either: sufficient information for reclassification; or a determination that the incident is genuinely unclassifiable, in which case the incident closes with no Party bearing responsibility.
- An Inconclusive finding does not affect Protocol compliance. Both Parties issue a joint statement affirming that the Protocol remains in full effect. Neither Party uses an Inconclusive finding to justify unilateral action.

6.7B Independent Attribution Review for Non-Signatory States

If an incident is potentially attributable to a non-signatory state (including but not limited to Israel, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, or Turkey), the Joint Attribution Panel requests an Independent Attribution Review from a neutral third-party expert panel selected from a pre-approved list maintained by the UN Secretary-General's office.

The Independent Attribution Review completes within 72 hours of the Panel's request, has access to all forensic materials collected by the Panel, and issues a binding determination on whether the non-signatory state was responsible. If the determination is positive, the Review

triggers the Third-Party False-Flag Protocol (Article 6.10A). If the determination is negative, the incident returns to the Panel for standard classification.

6.8 Human-in-the-Loop Review

Every Tier 2 and Tier 3 determination requires prior review by an Independent Technical Review Panel before any penalty takes effect. Automated systems inform; human officials decide. No penalty takes effect without human authorization at multiple levels:

- The Panel's technical review (48 hours): The Independent Technical Review Panel issues a written recommendation with findings of fact.
- The Joint Commission's review of proportionality (24 hours): The Joint Commission reviews the recommendation and determines whether the proposed response is proportionate to the event.
- Senior officials' review: Senior officials from both Parties review the Commission's determination before any response takes effect.
- Deferral option: If either Party's senior officials object to the proportionality assessment, the response defers for an additional 48 hours while the Parties consult directly.
- No automated system makes an autonomous penalty decision. No algorithm triggers a penalty. Human review occurs at every decision point within 24 hours of all automated flags.
- Annual Audit: The Joint Commission conducts an annual audit verifying that no automated system makes an autonomous penalty decision and that human review occurs within 24 hours of all automated flags. If the audit finds a violation, the Joint Commission recalibrates the automated system within 30 days.

6.9 Cross-Module Spillover Protection

Failure in one Protocol track does not automatically suspend implementation of any other track. The framework architecture maintains modular independence:

- If the proxy stand-down track experiences disruption, the mine clearance track continues. Certified zones remain open. Convoy operations proceed.
- If the maritime standstill track experiences disruption, the insurance stabilization track continues. DFC coverage remains active. Lloyd's ratings remain in effect.
- If the economic benefits track experiences suspension, the communication channels remain active. The Deconfliction Hotline continues. The Omani-Pakistani-Qatari backchannel remains open.

- The Joint Commission certifies by supermajority before any cross-module suspension occurs. Cross-module suspension requires a specific finding that the failure materially undermines the affected module.

Article 7: Proxy Forces and Regional Actor Management

The framework architecture defines specific proxy and partner behavioral categories, establishes measurable compliance indicators, and creates a verification mechanism for proxy stand-down. Vague instructions to "direct proxies to stand down" lack enforceability. This Article replaces vagueness with specificity. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

7.1 Defined Proxy and Partner Groups

For the purposes of this Protocol, the following behavioral categories are designated as proxy or partner forces subject to stand-down obligations. Confidential Annex B lists the specific organization names corresponding to each behavioral category. Publicly, this Article refers only to behavioral categories, not named organizations.

Iranian-aligned behavioral categories: Lebanese armed elements; Palestinian armed elements in Gaza; Iraqi Popular Mobilization Forces elements; Yemeni Ansar Allah elements; and Syrian militia elements operating under external coordination.

United States-aligned behavioral categories: Kurdish forces in Iraq operating under Combined Joint Task Force coordination; select Syrian Democratic Forces units; and Gulf state military forces operating under CENTCOM coordination.

Confidential Annex B lists the specific organization names corresponding to each behavioral category. Either Party proposes additions or removals to Annex B through mutual written notification to the Joint Commission with a 14-day review period.

7.2 Measurable Stand-Down Indicators

The framework architecture defines stand-down compliance through the following measurable indicators, verified by the UNODA Conventional Arms Branch (CAB), or another mutually accepted technical body, and regional UN field offices:

- Rocket and mortar fire: Zero launches across the Israel-Lebanon border, the Iraq-Jordan border, and the Yemen-Saudi Arabia border for 14 consecutive days.
- Drone and missile attacks: Zero one-way drone or ballistic missile launches by designated proxy groups against any target for 14 consecutive days.

- Maritime harassment: Zero confirmed interdiction, boarding, or attack on commercial vessels by designated proxy maritime units in the Red Sea, the Gulf of Aden, or the Strait of Hormuz for 14 consecutive days.
- Cross-border ground incursions: Zero ground force crossings of internationally recognized borders by designated proxy units for 14 consecutive days.
- Cyber operations: Zero confirmed cyberattacks by designated proxy groups against critical infrastructure, financial systems, or government networks of the other Party or its allies for 14 consecutive days.

7.3 Proxy Maritime Harassment

The framework architecture explicitly addresses proxy maritime harassment as a distinct category of conduct, given the high probability of such activity in the Hormuz region:

- "Proxy maritime harassment" means: small-boat swarming or close-approach tactics within 500 meters of a commercial vessel; drone overflight of commercial vessels at altitudes below 1,000 feet; laser targeting or illumination of vessel bridges; unauthorized boarding attempts; placement of improvised maritime obstacles in transit lanes; or sabotage of vessel navigation, propulsion, or communications systems by non-state actors.
- Small-boat shadowing of convoy vessels, drone overflight within 3 nautical miles of convoys, or placement of improvised maritime obstacles constitutes a Category B disruption unless attributed to a third party under Article 6.
- Verification of proxy maritime harassment relies on: vessel captain reports transmitted through UKMTO; AIS anomaly detection; SAR satellite imagery of vessel convergence patterns; and recovered debris or forensic evidence from vessel hulls.
- Proxy maritime harassment that does not result in vessel damage or injury maps to Category B material disruption. Proxy maritime harassment that results in vessel damage, injury, or operational shutdown maps to Category C deliberate hostile violation.
- Measurable Proxy Maritime Harassment Indicators: The Joint Commission tracks the following quantifiable indicators of proxy maritime harassment: small-boat approach distance (any vessel under 30 meters closing to within 200 meters of a commercial vessel in the corridor); drone overflight altitude (any drone flying below 500 feet above a commercial vessel); AIS shadowing (a vessel broadcasting a false identity that matches a convoy vessel or follows a convoy at matching speed for more than 15 minutes); laser targeting (any directed energy device illuminating a vessel bridge); unauthorized boarding (any individual boarding a commercial vessel without IMO or flag-state authorization); and maritime sabotage indicators (cut anchor chains, damaged propellers, fouled intakes, or GPS jamming affecting vessel navigation).

- **Distance Thresholds:** Small-boat approach within 500 meters triggers monitoring and logging. Approach within 200 meters triggers a Category A deviation review. Approach within 100 meters triggers a Category B disruption classification. Approach within 50 meters, or physical contact of any kind, triggers a Category C deliberate violation classification. These distances apply to any vessel under 30 meters in length operating within the Hormuz transit corridor.
- **Drone Altitude Limits:** Drone overflight of commercial vessels at altitudes below 1,000 feet above ground level triggers monitoring. Overflight below 500 feet triggers Category A deviation review. Overflight below 200 feet, or hover-station within 500 meters horizontal distance of a commercial vessel, triggers Category B disruption. Drone release of any payload, directed energy engagement, or kamikaze approach trajectory triggers Category C deliberate violation regardless of altitude.
- **Shadowing Definitions:** AIS shadowing means a vessel broadcasting a false identity that matches a convoy vessel's MMSI, call sign, or vessel name. Physical shadowing means a vessel maintaining station within 500 meters of a convoy vessel at matching speed (within 1 knot) for more than 15 minutes without legitimate operational justification. Both AIS shadowing and physical shadowing constitute Category B disruptions. Shadowing combined with small-boat approach within 200 meters constitutes Category C deliberate violation.
- **Threshold Classifications:** Small-boat approach within 200 meters without hostile intent constitutes Category A deviation. Small-boat approach within 100 meters, or laser targeting, or drone overflight below 200 feet constitutes Category B disruption. Small-boat swarming (3 or more small boats converging on a single vessel), or actual boarding, or confirmed sabotage constitutes Category C deliberate violation.
- Both Parties commit to issuing public warnings to all vessels transiting the corridor that proxy maritime harassment is a Protocol concern and that the Parties jointly investigate all reports.

7.4 Proxy Verification Mechanism

The framework architecture verifies proxy stand-down through a dedicated monitoring mechanism:

- The United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL), or another mutually accepted technical body, reports on Lebanese armed element activity in southern Lebanon.
- The United Nations Assistance Mission for Iraq (UNAMI), or another mutually accepted technical body, coordinates with Iraqi security forces to monitor PMF movement and activity.

- The UNODA Conventional Arms Branch (CAB), or another mutually accepted technical body, monitors conventional weapons flows and proxy group armament levels through its existing reporting mechanisms.
- Open-source intelligence analysts contracted by the UNODA CAB monitor social media, satellite imagery, and public communications of all designated proxy groups.
- The Joint Commission receives a consolidated weekly Proxy Activity Report from the UNODA CAB, indicating compliance or non-compliance for each indicator.

7.5 Lebanon De-escalation Working Group

The framework architecture integrates the existing US-Iran conflict avoidance coordination group for Lebanon as a dedicated working group under this Protocol:

- The Lebanon De-escalation Working Group comprises military officers from both Parties, UNIFIL representatives, and Lebanese Armed Forces liaison officers.
- The Working Group meets separately from the Joint Commission and focuses exclusively on preventing Israel-Lebanon border incidents from escalating into a broader regional conflict.
- The Working Group operates a dedicated communication channel through the existing conflict avoidance coordination group infrastructure, supplemented by the Omani relay.
- Findings of the Working Group feed into the Joint Commission's weekly compliance report but do not automatically trigger Protocol responses. Escalation to the Joint Commission occurs only if border incidents demonstrate clear Party involvement.

7.6 Proxy Non-Compliance Consequences

Proxy stand-down operates on the following consequence structure:

- If a designated proxy group violates a stand-down indicator, the sponsoring Party receives a Category A deviation notification and has 48 hours to demonstrate efforts to compel stand-down.
- If the sponsoring Party demonstrates credible efforts (public statements, direct communications with proxy leadership, visible force repositioning), the incident does not escalate.
- If the sponsoring Party fails to demonstrate credible efforts within 48 hours, the incident upgrades to Category B material disruption under Article 6.4.
- If the sponsoring Party is found to have directed, funded, or knowingly facilitated the proxy violation, the incident upgrades to Category C deliberate hostile violation under Article 6.5.

Article 8: Communication and Crisis Management

Continuous, reliable communication between the Parties prevents misunderstanding, resolves disputes before they escalate, and maintains the diplomatic channel even during moments of maximum tension. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

8.1 The 24/7 Deconfliction Hotline

The Deconfliction Hotline operates continuously between the Parties through the Omani relay. The Hotline handles operational military communications exclusively.

- The Hotline connects operational military commanders on both sides through the Omani Royal Navy as a neutral relay. No direct military-to-military communication between Iranian and United States personnel occurs unless both Parties expressly agree.
- Either Party initiates a Hotline call at any time, for any reason, without preconditions. The receiving Party responds within 30 minutes.
- Hotline communications remain confidential. Neither Party records, publishes, or references Hotline communications in public statements without the express consent of both Parties.
- Failure to respond to three consecutive Hotline calls within 30 minutes constitutes a Category A deviation, addressed through recalibration dialogue under Article 5A.

8.2 The Omani-Pakistani-Qatari Backchannel

The Sultanate of Oman, the Islamic Republic of Pakistan, and the State of Qatar serve as co-facilitators of the primary diplomatic backchannel for sensitive political communications:

- Omani, Pakistani, and Qatari diplomats relay messages between the Parties at the foreign minister level and below. This backchannel operates independently of the Deconfliction Hotline and handles political, not operational military, communications.
- The Omani facilitator drafts neutral technical assessments based exclusively on raw telemetry data and transmits them to both Parties simultaneously.
- The backchannel remains active regardless of the formal diplomatic status of the Protocol. Track II diplomacy through this channel continues even if technical compliance wavers.
- Pakistan's mediation role focuses on high-level political messaging and crisis intervention. Qatar's facilitation focuses on logistics, hosting, and technical coordination. Oman maintains the central coordination role for both the Hotline and the backchannel.

8.3 Public Communication Discipline

The framework architecture imposes mutual non-undermining obligations on public communications:

- Neither Party publicly characterizes a compliance concern as a breach before the Joint Commission issues a preliminary finding. A public declaration of breach made before the 48-hour cooling-off period expires is itself a Category B material disruption.
- Both Parties refrain from threats of military action, demands for surrender, or characterization of the other as an enemy in official statements during the term of this Protocol.
- Joint statements use only mutually agreed technical language. Each Party describes this Protocol to its own public in its own terminology. Neither Party requires the other to adopt specific labels such as concession, surrender, or victory.
- A joint communications working group coordinates messaging on implementation milestones, corrects misinformation, and builds public support for the Protocol in both countries.

8.4 Public Outrage Management and Communications Protocol

The Parties recognize that public outrage, media narratives, and domestic political pressure threatens Protocol viability even when both governments remain committed to de-escalation. The following Communications Protocol applies:

- **Joint Information Management:** Within 48 hours of Protocol signature, the Parties establish a Joint Communications Working Group (JCWG) comprising senior communications officials from both Parties plus the Omani facilitator. The JCWG coordinates messaging on implementation milestones, corrects misinformation, and builds public support for the Protocol in both countries.
- **Crisis Communications Protocol:** During any Category B or Category C event, or any Shock Event, the JCWG convenes within 2 hours to coordinate public messaging. The JCWG drafts a joint statement that acknowledges the incident in factual terms, affirms continued commitment to the Protocol, announces that the incident is under investigation through the Joint Attribution Panel, calls for calm and restraint, and does not attribute blame until the Panel issues its classification.
- **Right of Reply:** If either Party believes that inaccurate or distorted reporting about the Protocol or an incident under investigation has been published, it requests a correction through the JCWG. The JCWG drafts a joint response within 24 hours, which both Parties publish through their official channels. If the Parties cannot agree on joint language, each Party issues its own statement, but both statements affirm continued commitment to the Protocol and do not accuse the other Party of bad faith.

- **De-escalation Messaging:** During periods of heightened tension, both Parties commit to refraining from threats of military action in official statements, refraining from characterizing the other Party as an enemy, and using technical language to describe compliance issues rather than adversarial language ("deviation" rather than "breach," "adjustment" rather than "concession").
- **Public Protest Response:** In the event of public protests in either country related to the Protocol, both Parties affirm the rights of peaceful assembly and expression while maintaining that Protocol obligations remain binding on their governments. Neither Party uses domestic protest as justification for non-compliance or withdrawal.
- **Media Engagement Protocol:** Official briefings to domestic and international media are coordinated through the JCWG. Neither Party briefs media on compliance issues or incident investigations without prior consultation with the JCWG, except as required by domestic legal obligations (which are promptly notified to the JCWG).

8.4A Counter-Disinformation Working Group

The Joint Commission establishes a Counter-Disinformation Working Group (CDWG) comprising communications specialists, open-source intelligence analysts, and social media monitoring experts from both Parties, plus Omani and Qatari facilitators. The CDWG: monitors public communications, social media, and traditional media for disinformation related to the Protocol; identifies and flags false or misleading narratives about Protocol implementation, incidents, or compliance; coordinates rapid-response factual corrections through the JCWG; issues weekly public reports on disinformation trends affecting Protocol implementation; and does not attribute disinformation campaigns to specific actors unless the Joint Attribution Panel confirms such attribution.

Neither Party uses the CDWG to suppress legitimate political expression, criticism, or independent journalism.

8.4B Media Blackout Provisions for Shock Events

Article 5B.3's media blackout provisions are reinforced and extended:

- **Media Blackout:** During any Shock Event (Article 5B.1), neither Party briefs media, issues press releases, or conducts social media campaigns regarding the Shock Event until the Preliminary Shock Assessment (Article 5B.4) is issued.
- **Official Statement Limits:** Official statements during the Shock Protocol window are limited to: "The Parties are investigating the incident through the Joint Commission. Further information is provided when available."
- **No Attribution:** Neither Party attributes blame for a Shock Event in public statements until the Preliminary Shock Assessment is issued.

- **Violation Consequences:** A public statement violating this blackout is itself a Category B material disruption, subject to Tier 2 response under Article 6.4.
- **Social Media Monitoring:** Both Parties monitor their official social media accounts and ensure that no unauthorized communications are issued during the Shock Protocol window.

8.4C Non-Attribution of Third-Party False Flags

If the Joint Attribution Panel determines that an incident was staged by a third-party state (including but not limited to Israel, Saudi Arabia, or any other regional actor) with the intent to collapse the Protocol or provoke conflict between the Parties, the following applies:

- **Automatic Protocol Continuation:** The Protocol continues in full effect. No penalty or benefit reduction applies to either Party.
- **Joint Condemnation:** Both Parties issue a joint statement condemning the third-party state's actions within 6 hours of the Panel's determination.
- **UN Security Council Referral:** Both Parties refer the incident to the UN Security Council within 24 hours, requesting appropriate measures against the third-party state.
- **No Retaliation Against Other Party:** Neither Party uses the third-party false flag as justification for military action, economic sanctions, or diplomatic isolation of the other Party.
- **Enhanced Monitoring:** The Joint Commission enhances monitoring of the affected area for 30 days following a third-party false-flag determination to prevent recurrence.

Article 9: Economic and Humanitarian Safeguards

The framework architecture protects essential economic and humanitarian flows regardless of compliance disputes. These safeguards ensure that civilian populations do not suffer for political or military disagreements between governments. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

9.1 The Humanitarian Firewall

Humanitarian-badged disbursements pass through a one-way firewall and never reverse, even at the highest graduated response tier. The following flows remain protected under all circumstances:

- Medical supplies, pharmaceuticals, and humanitarian goods transit to Iran without sanctions enforcement. The OFAC General License covering humanitarian trade remains in effect regardless of compliance status.
- Food, agricultural commodities, water-treatment chemicals, civilian electrical grid transformers, and aviation safety parts move through pre-cleared commercial whitelist channels.
- The \$500 million pre-staged humanitarian tranche in the Swiss-domiciled escrow releases automatically upon Joint Commission timestamp confirmation and is immune to step-back at all tiers.
- United Nations agency operations, including the World Food Programme, UNICEF, and the World Health Organization, continue without interruption regardless of Protocol status.

9.2 Oil Revenue Stabilization

The framework architecture stabilizes Iranian oil revenue through transparent, escrow-protected mechanisms:

- Revenue from Iranian oil exports deposits into a monitored escrow at a Swiss-domiciled commercial bank, denominated in euros, renminbi, or UAE dirhams. Conversion rates lock to a Day-One currency basket to insulate Iran from exchange-rate shocks.
- Sixty percent of escrowed revenue releases monthly for verified civilian imports. Forty percent remains as a performance reserve, released only upon Joint Commission-certified completion of agreed milestones.
- If Brent crude spikes above \$115 per barrel, the oil export ceiling automatically expands from 1.0 million barrels per day to 1.3 million barrels per day. This trigger activates automatically and requires no diplomatic renegotiation.
- Tankers currently at sea at the moment of any step-back receive a guaranteed 14-day safe-harbor window to offload cargo. Neither the United States nor any allied jurisdiction applies secondary sanctions retroactively to cargoes loaded before the step-back date. This guarantee constitutes a core protection for Iranian oil export operations.

9.3 Frozen Asset Release

The framework architecture addresses the release of Iranian assets frozen in foreign jurisdictions:

- The Joint Commission establishes a Frozen Asset Working Group comprising financial representatives from both Parties plus officials from the jurisdictions where assets are held. The Working Group targets the release of approximately \$6 billion in frozen Iranian assets.

- The Working Group inventories all frozen Iranian assets exceeding \$10 million in value, by jurisdiction, by account, and by legal basis for the freeze, within 30 days of Protocol signature.
- Release proceeds in tranches: 25% upon completion of the inventory; 25% upon certification of the 60-day Stabilization Protocol; 25% upon signature of a comprehensive agreement under the Islamabad MOU; and 25% upon confirmation of continued Protocol compliance.
- Release of each tranche requires the consent of the jurisdiction where the assets are held. The Parties jointly request each jurisdiction to cooperate with the release schedule.

9.4 Banking Channel Protection

The framework architecture protects banking channels that facilitate legitimate trade:

- SWIFT reconnection proceeds in tiers for designated, pre-approved, non-IRGC-affiliated Iranian banks. The first tier reconnects within 45 days of signature, conditional on Joint Commission confirmation of an open Strait of Hormuz and sustained proxy stand-down.
- A third-party liability shield keeps non-United States financial institutions clear of secondary sanctions when processing transactions under this Protocol.
- Wind-down protection grandfathers all deposits and certified releases if sanctions reimpose. Companies wind down operations over 18 months without penalty.

9.5 Economic Impact Assessment

The framework architecture requires both Parties to agree to a joint economic impact assessment published every 30 days:

- The Joint Commission commissions an independent economic assessment from the UN Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD), or another mutually accepted technical body, evaluating the economic effects of the Protocol on both Parties and the global economy.

9.6 Economic Impact Communication

The Joint Commission commissions an independent assessment of the economic impact of any Category B or Category C event, or any Shock Event, on both Parties' economies, global energy markets, and shipping costs. The assessment completes within 14 days of the event, is published in full, without redaction, by both Parties within 5 business days of receipt, demonstrates the costs of escalation and the benefits of continued compliance with the Protocol, and builds public support for de-escalation by showing economic consequences of departure from the Protocol.

- The assessment covers: oil price stability, shipping cost indices, insurance premium trends, Iranian civilian economic indicators, and global energy market confidence metrics.
- Both Parties commit to publishing the assessment in full, without redaction, within 5 business days of receipt from UNCTAD.
- The assessment demonstrates Protocol benefits to domestic audiences in both countries and builds political support for continued compliance.

Article 10: United States Domestic Legal Compliance

The framework architecture acknowledges that the United States executive branch operates within a statutory framework that imposes procedural requirements for escrow deposits, sanctions waivers, and financial transactions. This Article specifies the required legal pathway and realistic timelines. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

10.1 Escrow Deposit Legal Pathway

The Maritime Economic Confidence Fund deposit proceeds through the following domestic legal process:

- The United States Department of the Treasury prepares a formal determination that the Fund deposit serves the national security interest of the United States by facilitating de-escalation of an active military confrontation.
- The Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) issues a specific license authorizing the transfer to the Swiss-domiciled escrow account within 10 business days of Protocol signature.
- If the OFAC determination requires interagency consultation beyond the standard 10-business-day window, the United States notifies the Joint Commission and the Islamic Republic of Iran within 24 hours, providing an estimated completion date not to exceed 15 business days.
- The Fund deposit is not contingent on prior Iranian action. The deposit proceeds on the United States' own statutory timeline as a unilateral procedural step, not as a reciprocal obligation requiring synchronized Iranian movement.

10.2 Oil Export Waiver Legal Pathway

The restoration of the oil export waiver proceeds through the following domestic legal process:

- The President of the United States issues a national security waiver under the Iran Sanctions Act, certifying that the waiver is essential to the national security interests of the United States.
- The Secretary of State and the Secretary of the Treasury jointly certify that the Islamic Republic of Iran has met the milestone-contingent conditions specified in Article 4.3 of this Protocol.
- OFAC publishes the waiver in the Federal Register and issues specific licenses to designated Iranian banks within 30 business days of the joint certification.
- If Congressional notification requirements under the applicable Congressional review statute apply, the United States provides the required notification and allows the statutory review period to elapse before the waiver takes full effect. The Parties acknowledge that this review period extends up to 30 days.
- The United States communicates the realistic timeline for each waiver step to the Joint Commission within 48 hours of Protocol signature, updating the timeline if procedural developments require adjustment.

10.3 DFC Political Risk Insurance Pathway

The United States Development Finance Corporation (DFC) political risk insurance program proceeds through the following statutory process:

- The DFC prepares a program determination that political risk insurance for Hormuz transit vessels serves the development and foreign policy interests of the United States.
- The DFC submits the program determination to Congress for notification. Congress has 15 days to review the determination before the program activates.
- If Congress raises no objection within the 15-day review period, the DFC activates the insurance program within 48 hours.
- If Congress objects, the DFC works with the Joint Commission to identify alternative insurance mechanisms, including private market reinsurance, while the statutory process continues.

10.4 Good-Faith Compliance

The United States commits to good-faith execution of all required domestic legal steps with deliberate speed. The Islamic Republic of Iran acknowledges that the United States domestic legal process imposes timelines that the executive branch cannot bypass. Neither Party treats the procedural execution period as non-compliance or delay.

Article 11: Commercial Insurance Stabilization

The framework architecture recognizes that commercial shipping cannot resume solely because military hostilities have paused. During Hormuz crises, Lloyd's of London and other marine insurers often suspend coverage or impose massive premium increases that render shipping economically unviable even when the strait is technically open. This Article creates the insurance stabilization mechanism that bridges the gap between military clearance and commercial viability. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

11.1 Joint Insurance Stabilization Notice

The framework architecture establishes a Joint Insurance Stabilization Notice coordinated with major marine insurers:

- Upon UNMAS certification of Zone A clearance, the United States and the Islamic Republic of Iran jointly issue an Insurance Stabilization Notice to Lloyd's of London, the International Group of P&I Clubs, and the major reinsurance markets in London, Bermuda, and Zurich.
- The Notice certifies that both Parties have agreed to a verified standstill, that a UN-led clearance operation is underway, and that both Parties commit to protecting commercial transit in the certified zones.
- The Notice includes a letter of comfort from the UN Secretary-General affirming that the United Nations stands behind the Protocol and that the United Nations deploys monitoring assets to verify compliance.
- The Notice specifies that neither Party attacks commercial shipping in the certified zones and that the classification and response framework of Article 6 addresses any attack, providing insurers with a verifiable risk-mitigation mechanism.

11.2 Lloyd's Joint War Committee Advisory Process

The framework architecture clarifies the role of Lloyd's Joint War Committee (JWC) and distinguishes advisory ratings from premium-setting:

- Lloyd's JWC does not set premiums directly. The JWC issues war risk advisory ratings that insurers then price against. The JWC's zone designations (Listed Area, War Risk Area, etc.) determine the baseline against which individual underwriters calculate premiums.
- Upon receipt of UNMAS certification, Lloyd's JWC convenes within 10 business days to review the certification, the Joint Insurance Stabilization Notice, and the DFC insurance program.

- The JWC issues revised zone designations for the Hormuz transit corridor. A downgrade from War Risk Area to Listed Area status signals reduced risk to the market and enables competitive premium pricing.
- The JWC's designation is advisory. Individual insurers retain pricing discretion. However, the JWC designation significantly influences market-wide pricing trends.
- Lloyd's JWC provides advisory update notifications to the Joint Commission within 24 hours of any change to war risk zone designations, advisory ratings, or listed areas affecting the Hormuz transit corridor. The Joint Commission shares these notifications with both Parties and the Shipping Industry Working Group within 6 hours of receipt.
- The Joint Commission and Lloyd's JWC maintain a direct communication channel for the duration of this Protocol. Either Party requests an emergency JWC consultation through the Joint Commission if a kinetic incident or Shock Event occurs. The JWC convenes within 48 hours of any such request.

11.3 Premium Stabilization Mechanism

The framework architecture creates a premium stabilization mechanism that prevents price spikes from halting shipping:

- The DFC provides political risk insurance for vessels transiting the certified zones, at premiums not to exceed 150% of pre-crisis rates for the first 30 days, subject to the Congressional notification requirements of Article 10.3.
- The DFC insurance program activates within 48 hours of Congressional clearance and covers hull, cargo, and third-party liability for all flagged vessels.
- The Maritime Economic Confidence Fund provides \$50 million in reinsurance backing for Lloyd's syndicates that underwrite Hormuz transit risks during the stabilization period.
- After 30 consecutive days of incident-free transit, the DFC premium cap reduces to 125% of pre-crisis rates. After 60 days, it reduces to 110%. After 90 days, commercial insurance markets resume normal pricing.

Article 12: Modular Continuity, Exit, and Framework Restoration

The framework architecture provides orderly pathways for both withdrawal and restoration. Either Party exercises these rights at any time. No Party remains trapped in an arrangement that no longer serves its interests. No provision of this Article creates a precedent for future negotiations.

12.1 Modular Continuity

Failure in one Protocol module does not suspend implementation of any other module unless the Joint Commission certifies by supermajority that the failure materially undermines the affected module. This principle governs all cross-module interactions:

- If the proxy stand-down track experiences disruption, the mine clearance track continues. Certified zones remain open. Convoy operations proceed.
- If the maritime standstill track experiences disruption, the insurance stabilization track continues. DFC coverage remains active. Lloyd's ratings remain in effect.
- If the economic benefits track experiences suspension, the communication channels remain active. The Deconfliction Hotline continues. The Omani-Pakistani-Qatari backchannel remains open.
- The Joint Commission certifies by supermajority (4 of 5 votes) before any cross-module suspension occurs. The affected Party's vote is excluded from this determination (Consensus Minus One). The Joint Commission's certification specifies the direct causal link between the failure and the undermining of the affected module. Generalized political dissatisfaction is insufficient.

Partial Success Doctrine: No single unresolved module invalidates the remainder of the Protocol. Each module operates as an independent operational track. Progress, compliance, or failure in one track does not automatically determine the status of any other track.

Practical result: if the proxy track fails, mine clearance survives, insurance survives, the Hotline survives, and the Fund survives. This is one of the framework's strongest structural protections.

6.10 Spoiler Designation and Response Protocol

The Parties recognize that non-signatory actors—including states, non-state armed groups, and rogue elements—seek to undermine this Protocol through kinetic, cyber, or disinformation operations. The following Spoiler Response Protocol applies:

- **Spoiler Designation:** The Joint Commission, by supermajority (4 of 5 votes), designates an actor as a "Spoiler" if it finds clear and convincing evidence that the actor has conducted an operation intended to derail, collapse, or discredit this Protocol.
- **Spoiler Attribution Standard:** A Spoiler designation requires corroboration from at least two independent intelligence sources (signals intelligence, human intelligence, open-source intelligence, or forensic analysis) plus a finding that the actor's conduct was deliberate and intended to undermine the Protocol.
- **Spoiler Response:** Upon Spoiler designation, both Parties issue a joint statement condemning the spoiling activity and affirming that the Protocol remains in full effect; both Parties suspend any direct or indirect cooperation with the Spoiler that affects

Protocol implementation; both Parties coordinate through the UN Security Council for appropriate measures (sanctions, diplomatic isolation, or other collective action); and neither Party uses the Spoiler designation as grounds for military action against the other Party.

- **Spoiler Linkage Investigation:** If credible evidence emerges linking a Spoiler to either Party, the Joint Attribution Panel (Article 6.7) reclassifies the incident under Article 6.5 (Tier 3 deliberate hostile violation).
- **Third-Party Spoiler Fallback:** If the Spoiler is a state actor that is not party to this Protocol, and that state's conduct materially undermines Protocol implementation, the Parties jointly request the UN Secretary-General to appoint a special envoy to address the spoiling behavior through diplomatic channels.

6.10A False-Flag Incident Rapid Response Protocol

The Parties acknowledge that false-flag operations—particularly those involving the misattribution of attacks to the other Party—pose a severe threat to Protocol viability. The following Rapid Response Protocol applies to all incidents where a Party alleges, or credible third-party reporting suggests, that an incident has been staged to appear as an attack by one Party on the other.

- **Immediate Joint Statement (within 6 hours):** Upon any public allegation of a false-flag incident, both Parties issue a joint statement affirming that they are investigating the incident through the Joint Attribution Panel and that they remain committed to the Protocol. The statement uses only mutually agreed language and does not attribute blame.
- **Attribution Deferral Window (48 hours):** No Party retaliates, imposes penalties, or publicly accuses the other Party during the 48-hour attribution deferral window (Article 6.2). This window applies regardless of media coverage or public outrage.
- **Enhanced Forensic Collection:** During the 48-hour window, the Joint Attribution Panel collects and preserves all sensor data, communications intercepts, and material evidence relevant to the incident. Both Parties grant the Panel immediate access to all forensic materials.
- **Third-Party Attribution Review:** If the Panel cannot conclusively attribute the incident to either Party within 48 hours, the Panel requests an independent forensic review by a neutral third party (selected from the pre-approved list maintained by the UN Secretary-General's office). The independent review completes within 72 hours.
- **No Presumption of Guilt:** Neither Party is presumed responsible for a false-flag incident simply because the incident occurred in its territory, involved its equipment, or benefited its strategic position. Attribution requires evidence, not inference.

- **Public Correction Obligation:** If the Panel determines that an incident was falsely attributed to a Party, both Parties issue a joint correction statement within 24 hours, publicly correcting the record and identifying the responsible actor (if known) or acknowledging the incident's inconclusive status.

12.2 The 14-Day Exit Ramp

Either Party withdraws from this Protocol on 14 days' written notice to the Joint Commission and the Depositary. The following rules govern withdrawal:

- During the 14-day notice period, all provisions of this Protocol remain in full effect. Neither Party accelerates military operations or suspends compliance during the notice period.
- The withdrawing Party notifies the Joint Commission of its intent to disengage. The Commission coordinates an orderly transition. No punitive financial transfer applies. The withdrawing Party retains its Fund contribution unless both Parties agree otherwise.
- No clawback of already-released humanitarian funds occurs. Humanitarian flows, medical supplies, and UN-agency operations continue uninterrupted regardless of withdrawal.
- SWIFT access suspends 90 days after the effective date of withdrawal, providing a transition period for banking relationships to adjust.

12.3 Clean-Break Withdrawal

Either Party withdraws on 30 days' written notice as a clean break. No punitive exit payment applies. No financial transfer accompanies clean-break withdrawal. Both Parties retain their Fund contributions. This mechanism provides a dignified, structured exit that avoids the appearance of collapse or defeat. No further claims arise from the withdrawal itself.

12.4 Force Majeure

The framework architecture provides comprehensive force majeure protection:

- "Force majeure" means natural disasters, major storms, tsunamis, earthquakes, pandemics, technical failures of monitoring equipment, satellite outages, or other events beyond the reasonable control of either Party that prevent compliance with a Protocol obligation.
- Either Party declares a force majeure event by written notification to the Joint Commission within 12 hours of the event. The Commission determines whether the event qualifies as force majeure within 24 hours.

- During a declared force majeure, all compliance deadlines extend by the duration of the force majeure plus 48 hours. No classification or response accrues during the force majeure period or the 48-hour recovery period.
- Both Parties cooperate to mitigate the effects of force majeure events on the Protocol, including sharing resources, personnel, and information where practicable.
- If a force majeure event persists for more than 14 consecutive days, either Party proposes a Protocol suspension. Suspension freezes all obligations and timelines. Restoration proceeds from the pre-suspension baseline.

12.5 Framework Restoration

If this Protocol suspends or terminates, the following restoration pathway remains available:

- Either Party proposes framework restoration to the Joint Commission at any time. The proposal specifies the terms on which the proposing Party is prepared to resume the Protocol.
- The Commission transmits the proposal to the other Party and convenes a session within 14 days.
- If both Parties agree, they sign a Restoration Agreement that specifies the resumed terms, any adjustments agreed during the suspension period, and a revised timeline.
- Restoration proceeds from the last verified compliance baseline. No Party starts from zero. Progress banks where it is made, and a localized failure stays localized.

12.6 Relationship to the Islamabad MOU

This Protocol operates in full subordination to the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding of 17 June 2026. In the event of any inconsistency between the provisions of this Protocol and the Islamabad MOU, the latter prevails. Nothing in this Protocol supersedes, amends, or derogates from the Islamabad MOU.

Nuclear file matters remain exclusively within the Islamabad MOU negotiating track. This Protocol does not address, condition, or reference the nuclear file in any operational, verification, compliance, or milestone provision.

The Parties view this Protocol as an emergency bridge that prevents collapse of the Islamabad framework while the 60-day negotiating window proceeds. Upon completion of a comprehensive agreement under the Islamabad MOU, this Protocol terminates automatically and the broader framework absorbs its provisions.

12.7 Depositary and Entry into Force

The Governments of the Sultanate of Oman, the State of Qatar, and the Islamic Republic of Pakistan serve as co-Depositaries of this Protocol. This Protocol enters into force upon signature by authorized representatives of both Parties. The Depositaries circulate certified copies to both Parties and to the United Nations Secretary-General.

12.8 Non-Party State Conduct Clause

This Protocol is an agreement between the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran. The conduct of non-signatory states—including but not limited to Israel, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Turkey, and any other regional or international actor—does not affect the obligations of the Parties under this Protocol.

In the event that a non-signatory state conducts a kinetic, cyber, or disinformation operation that affects the Hormuz transit corridor or the implementation of this Protocol; attempts to provoke conflict between the Parties; or stages a false-flag incident to collapse the Protocol, the Parties: issue a joint statement within 6 hours affirming that the Protocol remains in full effect; refer the incident to the UN Security Council within 24 hours; coordinate a joint diplomatic response to the non-signatory state; and do not use the non-signatory state's conduct as grounds for suspension, renegotiation, or termination of the Protocol.

This clause is non-waivable. Neither Party accepts a reservation to this clause.

Article 12A: Decoupling of Economic Penalties from Military Authorization

Under no circumstances does a compliance dispute, Tier 2 material disruption, Tier 3 deliberate hostile violation, step-back penalty, or Protocol suspension automatically authorize, trigger, or justify the use of military force by either Party.

- The step-back and earn-back architecture is purely economic and diplomatic. Military action requires separate, explicit decision by the respective head of government under constitutional procedures and consistent with Article 51 of the United Nations Charter.
- This decoupling is absolute and non-waivable. Either Party invoking a compliance event as justification for military action is itself a Category C deliberate hostile violation.
- The Joint Commission reaffirms this decoupling in every weekly compliance report. Both Parties' senior officials acknowledge this principle at the inaugural Joint Commission session.

Annex A: Implementation Roadmap

This Annex provides the detailed day-by-day implementation milestones, responsible parties, and verification criteria for each action item under this Protocol. The Roadmap commences on the date of signature (Day Zero).

Days 0-2: Signature and Standstill Activation

- Day 0 (Hour 0): Both Parties sign the Protocol. The Depositaries (Oman, Qatar, Pakistan) circulate certified copies. The 72-hour maritime standstill activates.
- Day 0 (Hour 2): The Joint Commission convenes its inaugural session in Muscat. Commission membership is confirmed.
- Day 0 (Hour 4): The Deconfliction Hotline activates through the Omani Royal Navy relay.
- Day 1: Iran declares known minefield locations to UNMAS and the IMO. The United States initiates OFAC licensing for the Maritime Economic Confidence Fund deposit.
- Day 2: UNMAS confirms receipt of the Iranian declaration. The CMF assembles the mine countermeasures survey team.

Days 3-5: Mine Clearance Phase I

- Day 3: The UNMAS-led survey team enters the Strait. Zone A (northbound lane) survey commences. The United States lifts the naval blockade for humanitarian traffic.
- Day 4: Zone A survey continues. Real-time data transmits to both Parties and the Joint Commission.
- Day 5: Zone A survey completes. UNMAS issues preliminary findings. The United States submits the Treasury determination for the Fund deposit.

Days 6-10: Mine Clearance Phase II

- Day 6: Zone A neutralization begins. Zone B (southbound lane) survey commences.
- Day 7: Zone A neutralization continues. Zone B survey progresses.
- Day 8: Zone C (Qeshm route) survey commences.
- Day 9: All three zones under active survey and clearance.
- Day 10: Zone A second-pass verification sweep.

Days 11-14: Maritime Reopening

- Day 11: UNMAS certifies Zone A. The IMO issues MSI broadcast. Lloyd's JWC receives certification.
- Day 12: UNMAS certifies Zone B. Commercial traffic resumes in Zones A and B under convoy rules.
- Day 13: Zone C clearance and verification.
- Day 14: UNMAS certifies Zone C. Full Strait reopening. The Joint Insurance Stabilization Notice issues.

Days 15-30: Early Stabilization

- Days 15-21: IRGC-Navy and Artesh Navy withdrawal from the transit corridor. US carrier strike group repositioning.
- Day 21: Both Parties confirm force withdrawals.
- Days 22-30: Full commercial transit normalizes under convoy system. Joint Commission reviews daily compliance.
- Day 30: First UNCTAD economic impact assessment published.

Days 31-60: Sustained Stabilization

- Days 31-45: Sustained proxy stand-down monitoring by UNODA CAB. UNIFIL reports on Lebanon. UNAMI monitors PMF activity.
- Day 45: First SWIFT reconnection tier activates for designated Iranian banks.
- Days 46-60: Continued compliance monitoring. Preparation for transition to Islamabad MOU comprehensive framework.
- Day 60: Final Joint Commission review. Protocol transitions to Islamabad MOU framework or terminates by mutual agreement.

Annex B: Pattern Repository

The Parties establish and maintain a Pattern Repository within the Joint Commission's secure data portal. The Repository serves as an anonymized archive of all deviations, classifications, adjustments, and outcomes under this Protocol. Its purpose is institutional learning, not compliance determination.

B.1 Contents

- Deviation records: all automated flags, classification decisions, and resolution outcomes.
- Adjustment records: proposed and implemented operational adjustments from recalibration dialogues.
- Contextual factors: seasonal, environmental, or operational conditions affecting compliance.

B.2 Governance

- Both Parties contribute equally through normal Protocol operations.
- Neither Party redacts Repository entries unilaterally.
- Disputed entries are flagged for facilitated review, not removed.
- The UN Secretary-General's representative maintains the Repository and publishes anonymized quarterly trend reports.

B.3 Use Restrictions

- Repository data is inadmissible as evidence in compliance determinations under any other annex or agreement.
- Neither Party uses Repository data to assert breach, violation, or non-compliance.
- Quarterly trend reports contain no attribution to either Party.

Emergency De-escalation Protocol

For the Strait of Hormuz Crisis

Signed at Muscat, Sultanate of Oman

All operative provisions employ active present-tense mutual architecture

Strictly adherent to the Immutable Present-Tense Matrix v2.5

Active Present-Tense Mutual Architecture